

Before we get started, I've one request: if there's anything that we go over at any point that you feel can't work, that's candor I want to make sure reaches me. For now, please send whatever feedback you might have directly to me at chris@empowered.vote.

Don't worry about trying to convince me – I'm convinced if you are. Just explain it to me so I can see it from your perspective.

And to highlight a distinction, I'm less concerned with why this won't work. I'm not focused on tactics just yet. So if it's anything that can be solved by applying enough effort or money or patience, then it's going to be a 'future us' problem.

For now, I'm looking for foundational feedback; why this can't or shouldn't work.

Approach this critically; when the time comes, we're going to want it to be able to support a lot of weight.



The 2 Mars Problems



The First Mars Problem refers to Mars, the God of War:

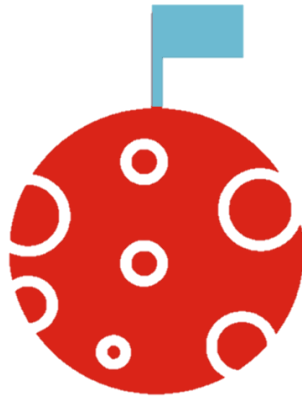
How do we end Mars before he ends us?

It's an old question. Orphans and widows have long cursed the steep price of war, their wisdom dismissed by the hubris of governments that ask us to settle their differences with violence.

Humanity has a long, brutish history filled with constant tribal and nationalistic violence. And we have inherited a planet already armed for Armageddon.

All the God of War needs to do is wait for a generation that doesn't fear his presence – and then he can watch as we wield weapons of casual annihilation to end all life on Earth.

That's the First Mars Problem.



The Second Mars Problem refers to the colonization of the red planet:

What should the Martian government look like?

Soon, we will send a generation out among the stars to colonize the heavens. I believe that moment also represents our last peaceful opportunity to collectively decide with forethought and intent what we believe the heavens should look like.

We have a generation, right now, to design for that colony a better way forward; developing a modern democracy that uses technology to empower its citizens. Connecting, protecting, and representing the entire colony equitably by building it upon a foundation of well-defined and commonly shared, inalienable values.

What's the best government we can design for the settlers of the first Martian colony?

That's the Second Mars Problem.

I'm a game developer by trade. I make board games and video games and design systems that I think will leave people feeling engaged. I love what I do.

A few years back, I started getting worried about the future of Democracy. Not just here in the US – but representative governments all over the planet seemed to be in pretty steady decline.

So I took a look at the hand I'd been dealt, and I started studying the problem through the lens of what I knew: Games. Initially, it felt an awkward fit – but we don't always get to choose our cards, only how we play them.

I looked at the engagement frameworks and retention patterns that I'd picked up while making games – and then for years on my nights and weekends, I applied those tools and techniques towards building a set of social civic designs.

The current culmination of that is what I'd like to share with you now.

The origins, guiding values, and roadmap for Empowered.Vote.



I'll summarize the chapters that follow:

- 1 **why** - I start at the crossroads of Technology and Democracy, where I found three distinct frustrations to focus upon.
- 2 **who** - I'll describe three lenses I used to see our solution.
- 3 **how** - With those priorities established, I'll introduce Empowered.Vote – a not-for-profit social media platform designed to facilitate healthier civic engagement.
- 4 **priorities** - Within Empowered.Vote, we use Game Theory to unpack the values that collectively guide our solutions. This process is repeatable, transparent and allows our platform to indefinitely be guided by the goals of our community.
- 5 **what** - After that, I'll explore the three pillars of our platform and introduce features that demonstrate what our values look like in action.
- 6 **risks** - In our penultimate chapter, I explain our evergreen stewardship including foundational decisions involving our business model and why access to our community will never be sold as a commodity.
- 7 **2mp** - And then I'll circle-back at the end to revisit the Two Mars Problems.

1 why

I find focusing on a shared problem is critical in landing on any type of shared solution. So here is my problem:

Modern technology should be empowering our democracy.

And right now, it doesn't.

This is something my generation watched unfold in real-time. We were among the last to grow up in a world that was 'unconnected'; a time before the Internet. As an adult, I watched the proliferation of technologies like cell phones and personal computers reshape our society. And my generation will be the last to remember the trade-offs, first-hand, the before-and-after of what we gained and gave up in exchange for our technological advances. Of what was promised and then what was delivered.

And what we do with that wisdom will be how future generations define us.

So I took stock of my frustrations with technology and started sorting them into three distinct buckets; each focused upon a separate grievance, and much of what comes next will be built upon this sorting.



The first and most foundational grievance was that technology had promised to keep us all informed. Knowledge can now travel the globe in an instant! Never in human history should we as a species be more informed than we are right now.

Gone are the days of the telegraph or long-distance phone calls. We can now watch live streams from all over the planet and translate local newspapers from remote corners of the world, effortlessly. We have at our fingertips access to more accurate information than any generation that has come before us.

And yet, we live in an era of 'Fake News' where we must fight to discern fact from fiction and we're encouraged to dismiss the narratives that we don't find convenient.

I refer to this murky ambiguity that prevents all of us from sharing the same facts as 'Information Pollution' and I started throwing a lot of different, but related, problems into this first bucket.

The most obvious example of Information Pollution is the spreading of falsehoods – either by accident with misinformation – or intentionally with weaponized disinformation.

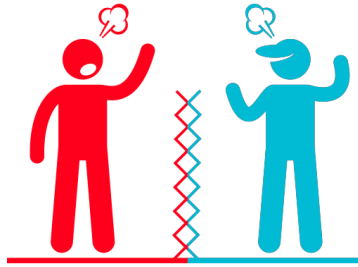
But Information Pollution also comes in other forms that are a bit more insidious to spot. It refers to the way we scroll through a terms-of-service agreement, being flooded with so much mind-numbing lawyer-speak that you don't even bother understanding what you're committing to – what rights you are trading away – when you press 'Accept'.

Information Pollution is the practice of parading logical fallacies about as if they were facts in an effort to prey upon our most vulnerable. It's the targeted weaponization of our biases, exploiting them so that we become easier to manipulate; linking unrelated problems to goad us into taking aim against our own interests.

Information Pollution is the normalization of propaganda, where our knowledge of the world comes to us pre-filtered through the perspectives of political pundits.

In order for us to have a productive place to disagree, we must first see our challenges with the same clarity.

So Information Pollution became my first bucket.



My second grievance stems from the various ways technology connects us to each other.

Over the course of one generation, we developed the capability to connect with every person on the planet. But instead of pairing this reach with our growing understanding of cognitive and behavioral therapy to facilitate healthier conversations, our technology has left us polarized. It's divided us neatly into separate echo chambers of outrage, where no meaningful dialogue takes place.

Our public communication is now privately governed by social media platforms who approach their communities as commodities. Their financial ecosystems built upon a bedrock of surveillance capitalism – where every keystroke is captured, categorized, analyzed, and then sold to the highest bidder.

This misalignment of values within the business model creates a vulnerability in our modern civic discourse that is being exploited to make us target each other. Interests that operate outside our democracy are using these platforms to keep our nation polarized.

We get placed across a politically charged battlefield where the loudest, most abrasive voices are the ones that get amplified. And as the abuse grows more vitriolic outside our doors, we are encouraged to isolate within our insulated echo chambers, where we divide our communal power and become easier to manipulate.

It's not that we haven't discovered how to facilitate difficult conversations productively or systemically. It's that we allowed our technology to grow with a different focus than our society's interests as its goal. The algorithms that choose what pops up next in your feed are not governed by shared values; for-profit companies first claim a fiduciary obligation to their shareholders. These organizations do not exist to help us solve shared problems but to drive traffic and sell access to the most easily influenced based upon their identified vulnerabilities.

For example, when you encounter a person that knows the earth is flat, you can exploit many of the same techniques and logical fallacies that brought them to that conclusion to get them to believe almost anything else. And we sell access to this person to anyone in the world that wants it.

Our most vulnerable are being separated from the rest of the pack and preyed upon through the targeted bombardment of disinformation, logical fallacies, and the surgical exploitation of their cognitive biases.

Simply put, our society is not built to withstand this new form of cyber warfare. We need a social platform that prioritizes the protection of our civic conversations. That works to ensure that our discussions aren't being guided – or intentionally polarized – by profiteers or those only pretending to be our countrymen.

Having anonymity in the places where we determine our public opinion is going to be a growing problem as our technology continues to evolve. Even if we set aside the growing threat of deepfakes capable of misrepresenting our world leaders during a time of crisis, it has become increasingly difficult to tell the difference between real people and computers in even a forum setting. And as our technology crosses the threshold where most of us can't tell the difference, it is going to be quite easy for someone to program a chatbot with a specific civic agenda, and then replicate that program indefinitely. Attaching itself to anonymous Twitter, Facebook, Instagram and Reddit accounts, creating racist and polarizing posts, raging back and forth at *itself* while using strawman arguments to flood our conversations with an artificial perspective while actively supporting an insidious agenda. Every day this technology grows more refined while this vulnerability in our civic discourse remains undefended.

I took my frustrations with the way modern technology connects us – everything from surveillance capitalism actively targeting our most vulnerable to foreign actors using anonymity to flood our conversations with disinformation – and I threw these problems into a second bucket that I called 'Political Polarization'.



My third and primary grievance I introduced at the top of the chapter: I believe modern technology should be empowering our democracy.

I've always had a profound fascination with the founding of my nation. As I was growing up, I'd glimpse technologies beyond the horizon that promised to extend society's reach in some new way. And then my mind would race through the possibilities of what our forefathers would have created with this new advantage. If they hadn't been limited by quill pens and candlelight, if they'd had access to satellites and cell phones and wielded a modern understanding of what makes a person, what might they have made for us, instead? What would they have kept consistent? What would they've changed with the wisdom of hindsight?

As a child, I didn't understand what motivated such a change, so I waited patiently for those in power to follow in the footsteps of our tech industry to modernize our democracy and empower our citizens. It would be some time before I knew to look for shared problems or realized that diminishing centralized power was not a frequent goal of those who also hoarded it.

But in those intervening years, my childhood was filled with the dreams of a democracy that I knew was just beyond our horizon. I'd imagine the ways our new technology would give an equitable voice to those without. How the internet would completely restructure our systems of government to amplify the impact of citizens, eliminate bureaucracy, and provide a transparent paper trail in areas known to pool corruption.

But that impact never came. Or it came, but arrived with the wrong set of goals.

For instance, we now have the capability to run polls constantly and effortlessly to better understand what average citizens are thinking on any given topic – in a way that our forefathers would have only dreamed of! But we don't use this technology to better guide our government – instead the entire operation is funded by political consultants to know where to best target the spends for their ad-buys. From a design perspective, the goals of this system are not aligned with the goals of its audience but at their audience's expense.

I refer to this lack of impact on our democratic process by citizens as 'Civic Impotence' and believe it stems from two separate but connected places: money and politics.

Let's start with money; previous generations have allowed unlimited contributions to flood into our political systems from countries and interests who have goals counter to that of our nation's prosperity. This alone would normally be enough for reform, but in our current system, those who we've tasked with reforming can't remain in office long without the financial support of the donor class.

With the cost to mount a competitive federal election now in the millions, we have citizens who wish to run for office but cannot afford the entry fee to compete in our electoral process. In order to govern in our country, we've made it so that you either need to be independently wealthy (which probably shapes your perspectives a bit) or you must go hat in hand to the people who have the money. But donations of that scale don't frequently come without strings attached.

Any democracy that requires wealth to get elected will primarily serve the wealthy.

So if you feel our government is not working for your interests or listening to your concerns – then it is only because you don't have the funds to purchase its attention. Not having enough money is the reason why many citizens feel they can't make an impact upon our democracy. For a system of government designed to amplify the will of the people, this seems foundationally incorrect, so 'money' went into my final bucket of grievances.

There is another source of civic impotence which was initially more difficult for me to spot due to the way it hid amongst my biases. It's the way we've attached ourselves to our political parties as if they were our favorite sports teams. In the wrong hands, this type of tribalism can be exploited to have emotionally charged wedge issues determine your positions on a host of unrelated issues that you wouldn't have otherwise supported.

For example, why should a person's stance on abortion also determine their acceptance of climate change? Outside of politics, those two problems have nothing to do with each other. Why do we link them? Why should a voter's position on hand guns also determine who they believe should receive the largest tax cuts...? These are dramatically different issues.

But when we only have two viable options in an election, then we begin to link unrelated problems together. And in doing so, we solidify the power of those who lead political parties at the expense of understanding and aligning around the nuances of what voters want.

When we constrain our elections to a binary choice, we force voters to choose for or against an entire agenda – the red team or blue team. In this way, it becomes very easy to convince people to vote

against their interests by constraining their focus to a handful of emotionally charged wedge issues while letting more nefarious decisions get lost amongst a storm of information pollution.

When two people put on the armor of their political party before engaging in a discussion, then there's not an argument that either side could make that would change the stances of the other person's party. That's not how groupthink works. But if instead of defending a party's beliefs, we are simply asked to represent our own perspectives... in that conversation, progress is at least capable of being made since a person can choose to adjust their stance at the moment they are ready while a political party cannot.

In summary, this is why I'm here. The three problems I set out to solve:

Information Pollution

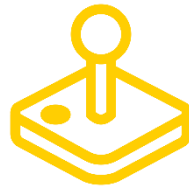
Political Polarization

Civic Impotence

If these sound like shared problems, in the next chapter, I'll describe the ways I see our solution.

2 who

There are three lenses I'd like to explore in this chapter. The first is my lens as a game developer. The second lens is the one I use for you, describing the audience I envisioned for this book. And the third lens explains who we are building our solution for and why that has no overlap with the other two lenses.



Making games has shaped the foundational frameworks that I use for exploring large problems. It was in game development that I learned how critical it is to approach your systems through the eyes of your audience. In this, I suspect games are much like any other service oriented endeavor: the more specific you are with understanding the motivations of whom you are building it for, the more focused the service you can provide.

Where I learned to develop games, we called this approach being player-focused. While other studios might pride themselves on developing the best graphics or gameplay or chase analytics that would maximize their profits, the developers I came to admire placed all other priorities behind the needs of their audience. Since we all played games ourselves, it was easy for this shorthand of being 'player-focused' to be broadly shared. We might disagree about what path served players best but we never disagreed that serving players best was the path.

I remember thinking when I first encountered this player-focused framing that it sounded like marketing speak; something you might find hanging in an employee break room or splattered in grease behind a register. For me, it's not the words that make a promise but the actions that follow. To see anyone with clarity, I can't listen to the values they celebrate while in calm waters; I have to watch for the ones they won't abandon when the seas get rough.

And from what I could tell, this player-first philosophy was at our core. It was firmly embraced by our founders with an infectious enthusiasm and so its prioritization existed outside of the traditional hierarchical constraints of an org chart. We still had managers for accountability and initiatives with cross-disciplined teams, but it was also widely understood that everyone – no matter their role – would be held responsible in defending their decisions from the perspectives of players. This value-driven framework gave us shared ownership to hold each other accountable, leading to an extraordinarily flat organization while on this topic of player-experience.

It was empowering; the autonomy to find problems, own them, see them through to completion and then watch the ways that made players' lives better. This simple framing encouraged an exploration of first principles – the type of questions that start with 'why' - to solve traditional problems in original ways. No matter the nature of the challenge, we sought to have our solutions originate from the player's perspective and primarily for their benefit. If that wasn't feasible or sustainable, then we made begrudging concessions from that empathetic vantage point to get as close as we could to that mark. Over time, this value-driven approach led us to a very different understanding of the underlying problems that we faced. We found that when we sincerely prioritized the player experience, it would act as a magnet around our guiding compass, constantly pivoting the focus of our needle towards solving the issues that mattered the most to players.

I'd like to provide a few specific examples of this prioritization of values that I witnessed, because I see the threads of my admiration echoed in what I went to build next. But in order for those decisions to have necessary context, I'd like to briefly describe how the business model of video games has evolved over the last fifteen years.

For most of my life, the traditional way to develop a video game was to take out a loan from a bank or investment firm, spend some number of months/years building that game, and then when it was finished (or you ran out of money), you would find a publisher to sell it for \$60 a box and hope that you moved enough units in that first month to pay back your investors. Much like the movie industry, a game studio either made their investment back during those critical first weeks of launch or they weren't going to be making it back at all. New video games get released constantly, pushing last month's smash hit to the bottom of the bargain bin. After that initial spike at launch, it was rare for a game to find another audience. Because of this limited window of viability, increased focus was placed on marketing the game, regardless of its quality.

From a venture capitalist's perspective, this long runway for development and short window for release made for familiar challenges when working with industry veterans. Even with these risks factored in, video games consistently made for a smart investment; with the overall market value of the sector having grown year-over-year for decades.

But when we look at this same value proposition through the eyes of a player, we can immediately start to see pain points that the venture capitalist isn't as concerned by. For starters, \$60 is a lot to spend on entertainment – especially for a kid. While some markets might hold sustainably at that price, many players would need to save their allowance for weeks only to discover that the game they had just purchased was a lousy fit for their tastes.

As new markets were emerging around the world, many families were gaining access to their first computers and smart phones, but were still unable to afford the steep price of a \$60 game. Due to how easily software could travel the globe, game publishers were reluctant to charge discounted rates for players in developing markets out of fears it would cannibalize the sales in the markets that would sustain them. This introduced a void where a growing number of players existed in these emerging markets, but were poorly served by traditional game studios. In these areas, another approach to monetization began to take root: Free-to-Play.

Free-to-Play represented a foundationally different business model, where developers would give a portion of their game away for free, and then keep other parts of the experience behind a paywall or sell access of their player base to advertisers. How this was done and what parts were free would vary from game to game, but it was always done with the hope that players would enjoy playing that free game long enough to eventually be worth some amount of money later.

This shift towards Free-to-Play may sound like a kindness, but in practice it tended to be indicative of something more insidious afoot; the equivalent of providing a gift card that could only be redeemed at a casino. Free-to-Play solved for the player regret of purchasing a game they didn't like, but it came with an unspoken shift in the relationship between players and their game developers. Where previously, the inherent motivation of a developer was to create a product that would be competitive at a \$60 price point, this focus was still largely on the product.

But in Free-to-Play markets, it's not the initial point of purchase that would bring in the revenue; the game was being given away for free, after all. Instead, a Free-to-Play studio's survival was found in keeping players engaged long enough to eventually monetize. Since the average players in these markets tended to have less money, the predominant strategy was to create a wide funnel to get as many users as they could into their ecosystem, with the hope that a subset would eventually decide to pay.

This shift in focus from the game to the player incentivized studios to monitor players' behavior and run countless experiments to determine the most compelling ways to make that engagement profitable. What stimuli or play patterns would effectively encourage a micro-transaction or have a player be willing to sit through an advertisement? You can see the difference in the values guiding both approaches when you contrast their output; the games both models would go on to produce. When it

was a \$60 purchase, the gameplay, graphics, story... they all had to at least be competitive with the rest of the market or players wouldn't be willing to buy the game in the first place; this competition meant that, over time, the quality of games kept getting better.

But in a Free-to-Play environment, the focus had shifted away from crafting complex or immersive gameplay in lieu of simple game loops; players might be asked to match three symbols in a row or watch a timer count down and press a button. Developers found through experimentation that when the complexity of their game was low, it appealed to a much broader audience. And when the complexity was extremely low, it appealed to those most likely to monetize. Free-to-Play studios would pair trivial accomplishments with bombastic celebrations using a technique similar to the psychology behind slot machines, where the goal is to keep the gambler playing for as long as possible. By loudly celebrating trivial victories, the casino can help the gambler overvalue their gains and remain eager to keep playing, even as their wallet dwindles.

When you strip away the satisfaction of solving complex problems from a game but leave behind the loud celebrations of success, you create the capacity for a game developer to 'feed' dopamine to players on a cadence that is set by the studio. After the player becomes accustomed to this saturation of celebrations, the studio can reduce their frequency and use the ensuing withdrawal to motivate the player to monetize.

When we look at the values it professes, Free-to-Play is built upon a pillar of accessibility that has real advantages for players. So it is only when we study the model's repeated output that we can see its guiding values with clarity: Free-to-Play is consistently predatory upon the player. Like a pit boss at a casino or a politician that just got back from a fundraiser, we should be wary of the inherent motivations of those that design our systems.

It's with this backdrop of video game business models that I want to explain how a simple value-driven framework can act as a compass through treacherous waters. But instead of extolling the values of being player-focused, I'll show examples; I find professed values easy to imitate where outcomes are not. None of these examples describe my decisions; I was able to closely view their impact and from that vantage point I'd like to share what I learned as I drew inspiration from a courage that may be difficult to spot in hindsight.

My first example of this output was the way our shared values led us to a new business model, simply by insisting every developer repeatedly ask the same question at every crossroads: What would ultimately be best for the player? Because this brief test was easy to execute, fully understand, and applicable to every type of problem, any developer in the studio could leverage this framework to quickly establish alignment or guide complex discussions with a precision that was broadly shared; like looking down upon a shared compass.

It was our collective, unwavering focus upon serving the needs of players that led to a new business model, one that would take the best from its predecessors – where the ‘best’ would always be defined through the lens of the player. At first glance this approach resembled Free-to-Play, since we also gave our game away for free and sought to understand what players wanted with an ongoing focus. But our goals were different - and in system designs, the goals of the designer matter quite a bit. Where Free-to-Play sought to extract as much money as possible from every player they encountered, our focus on service had us earnestly seek a long-term relationship with players. Where larger studios would ignore the constant chatter of players to focus on building the best game they could, we engaged casually and frequently with players to understand and build the game that they wanted.

This focus on serving players led us to a quality bar in graphics and gameplay that far surpassed traditional Free-to-Play games – whose output more closely resembled a slot machine – and eventually came to rival the output of much larger AAA studios. While we weren’t as skilled or as experienced as our well-funded competition, our commitment to being player-focused gave us an advantage the longer we stayed at it.

We found when we approached our game as a service, we were never really done; we were always tinkering, always iterating, always trying to make what we had already built better. It’s not that other studios weren’t aspiring to make the best game they could, too, it’s that the traditional \$60/box business model required them to ship and start over on a new game every few years, just to hit payroll.

With our focus on service, player-informed iterations were able to happen far more frequently; with feedback loops completing between players and developers in a matter of weeks instead of a matter of years. This constant pivoting to serve the needs of our audience was crucial in determining where we settled amongst our competitors, because we never allowed ourselves to settle.

This did not come without a steep cost – our prioritization of players over profits made it difficult to find aligned publishing partners, as each was really only eager to invest in ‘sure bets’ by using established practices. At that time, the only publishers that were comfortable with the insane idea of giving the game away for free were the same ones that would insist we adopt the predatory practices of Free-to-Play. In refusing both, our small, independent studio - that had never shipped a game before – was condemned to also become an independent publisher.

This leads to my second example of our player-focused framework, a second output that is difficult to insincerely imitate: our stance on selling power.

When I was growing up, I would find my sanctuary, my haven, in the neon lights and cathode hum of coin-operated arcades (it’s how I landed on the handle I still use online, ‘Kades’). So it was from a very early age that I was conditioned by the concept of paying more money to have a better chance to win.

I'd get dropped off with a small pocket of quarters that I'd be able to play until they ran out – always wistfully carrying my last one about as I agonized over what I wanted to play last. From a gameplay standpoint, these arcade cabinets were frequently balanced to make you feel powerful but still required that you 'feed' the game a steady stream of quarters as you ran out of lives.

This led to a frustration that got normalized over the years, where the kid down the street who had access to a bucket full of quarters, would always beat the game first, placing his initials at the top. I could go further on a quarter, sure, but he always had more. This imbalance isn't typically the case when you play board games, where the rules are enforced by the players. If you show up at game night, and the host places your pieces on Start and places theirs beside the finish line, it'd raise a red flag that the game you were about to play wasn't very fair and probably not worth your time. But video games have long reinforced that the more you spend, the better you'll do.

Decades later, Free-to-Play would turn this adage of Pay-to-Win into a calculated science. The most profitable studios would balance their games in the player's favor and then, once the player became invested, studios would slowly tweak the difficulty of the gameplay to be more punishing. Eventually, the player would need to purchase powerful in-game equipment in order to progress further in the campaign or be competitive in multiplayer - items which could only be acquired by spending real money. By that point, the hook had been set.

It's not just in games, selling power has always presented an obscenely profitable path the more popular your platform becomes. We could all see with a sharp clarity the profits that we were leaving behind by not going Pay-to-Win; it's not that we missed it. It's just no one was able to make a compelling argument that this lucrative monetization was also player-focused. Since we all had that shared compass, we all knew that mattered more. The health of a game is dependent on keeping it fair for all players. It's only when every player has an equal opportunity at the start of a game, that we should place any value on where they land at the end.

So instead of making a mint selling power, we decided to sell costumes that gave no advantage in gameplay, not knowing at the time if it would be enough to keep us afloat.

My third example of this player-focused framing also explores our profits, but it focuses on how we spent them instead of how we acquired them. By making a game that was accessible to a global audience, we reached a great many players that had previously only been preyed upon. We listened, iterated, and earnestly tried to build the game players wanted. By refusing the profits that came with Pay-to-Win, we had preserved the integrity of the gameplay – where it would consistently be the most skilled player that succeeded, regardless of whom had the biggest bucket of quarters.

These decisions and countless others were guided by a collective compass that sincerely sought to serve strangers. This player-focused compass had taken us through the shallow rocks of financial uncertainty and brought us to the relative safety of deep waters. The once treacherous and winding banks that can so callously destroy small studios now spanned behind us across the horizon. At this point we'd found safe passage and no longer had any need of a compass that would keep us from crashing into the shore. And yet, still, we clung to it.

We looked down at our needle, and now that we had the means to do whatever players wanted, we asked what did they want more than anything else...? With deliberation we landed on 'validation'. We sought to legitimize playing video games culturally by developing the necessary infrastructure so that players could pursue our game, professionally.

In a way that a founding publishing partner would have never allowed, we funded the prize-pools of tournaments all over the planet. Players anywhere in the world could indefinitely play our game for free and then go on to earn life-altering cash prizes. We established local leagues with analysts and color commentators in every language we could. This infrastructure included minor leagues and collegiate programs, that funneled from our ranked play online. We sold-out the largest arenas in the world and placed players in front of screaming fans as they competed at the highest levels. We envisioned and built the infrastructure for the first global e-sport, not because it made financial sense to our investors, but because it made sense to us as players. And in less than a decade, our small start-up that couldn't find a publishing partner had more people watching our World Finals than the Super Bowl. We had built for players a valid aspiration.

These three examples: our shared compass, our refusal to sell power, and our aim to empower – I will return to each, shortly.

I wanted to start with my lens, this specific type of game development, where there is broad horizontal empowerment using shared values in service of strangers. This first lens shaped me and the way I see the systemic problems in our world, and I hope it continues to influence everything that I build after.



The second lens is the one I've given to you. I seek those searching for shareable solutions to information pollution, political polarization, and civic impotence. With only those people and guided by their feedback, we're building a civic hub that uses value-driven frameworks to make Democracy healthier. If you are earnestly searching for a solution that you expect to be embraced by everyone involved, then it doesn't matter how liberal or conservative your policies are – you are in the purview of this lens. You are the voice we seek to empower.

But that's not intended to describe everyone; it can't. In order to serve those searching for shareable solutions, we must withhold support from those seeking its inverse. With this needle as our guide, we construct a new collective compass. This brief test, 'Am I searching for a shareable solution?', is easy to execute, innately understood, and applicable to every type of problem.

In the previous chapter I explained why I began developing Empowered.Vote, dividing my civic frustrations into three primary problems. With the goal of fully articulating my audience, I'd like to revisit each of these problems through a lens that constantly seeks to find shared solutions.

I'll start with Information Pollution; because in order to have any hope of us solving the same problems, we must first see our challenges with a shared understanding. Those comfortable exploiting others to achieve their ends will not be worried with seeing our problems with shared clarity and will seek to amplify our ambiguity while dismissing any attempts to find shared evidence. To the Liar, the Cheater, and the Bully, every obfuscation around our knowledge represents an evergreen tactical advantage; the more dust that gets kicked up, the more power each innately wields. But this inclination to avoid the acceptance of a common ground can be used to systemically find those among us that we don't wish to empower.

As an example, the next time you are disagreeing with someone and uncover that it's not their values you are in conflict with, but their facts... watch how you both respond to that realization. Everyone that is genuinely seeking a shared solution will always long for a shared understanding of the problem. Because without a mutual understanding, the best that discussion can aim to achieve is manipulation. When anyone rejects the pursuit of shared information as a foundation, they reveal themselves as not searching for shareable solutions. In this way, our collective compass reveals us to each other; because those who earnestly seek shared solutions will always long to use the same facts.

Wanting to see the same facts isn't the same as *recognizing* the same facts – different perspectives may see the same event and be justified in embracing different conclusions. But when a person realizes their crossroads are built from confusion instead of misalignment, they ultimately have two choices: either keep searching for a shared understanding or absolve themselves of finding clarity. Our collective

compass that seeks shared solutions will always point us towards the former. These informed conversations give us a foundation to solve our challenges for the same reason; creating solutions that last for everyone involved. When we pierce through the opaque clouds of Information Pollution and gaze upon the same problems, together, we create answers that stem from our collective values instead of our confusion.

This talk of values brings our compass of shared solutions to our second problem, Political Polarization. Polarization is the embrace of values that don't need to be shared. When we allow ourselves to become polarized, we stop looking for a shared response to our problems and become comfortable with answers that are found at the expense of others. As our polarization increases, the more isolated our values become and the less humane we approach those who don't share them. Any solution that is designed to be broadly shared will not also seek to be polarizing.

By limiting our discussions to the areas where we agree – both in our facts and our values – and then building our solutions only upon those places where we have found alignment, we create a systemic salve for society's polarization that points us toward shared solutions. Since the reasons at the center of these aligned solutions are shared by everyone involved, they last for a very long time without any need of oppression to be reinforced. Shared facts used with shared values will always point us towards shared solutions.

Value-Driven Framework



Our compass again reveals us to each other by our actions - because those who long for shared solutions will seek to build their answers using only values that they expect to be broadly shared. It's not that all of our values must align, but when our aim is to find a shared solution, then we must only use the values that sincerely overlap between us. Our work, then, is in framing our problems and constructing our solutions using only the subset of facts and values that we expect to be broadly embraced.

But for all their longevity, there is a frustrating limitation in value-driven designs: It is very easy to lie about our values. Due to the mercurial nature of sincerely held beliefs, it can be difficult to distinguish a person who loudly professes their values from the person who insincerely imitates the same. Just because someone emphatically claims a value doesn't mean they seek to embody anything that resembles their claim.

Many chase privately held solutions, recognizing their goals would never be broadly embraced if ever fully understood. Like an advertising agency or a defense attorney, they first lock-in on a desired outcome and then work backwards to find facts or values that would support them landing upon that predetermined conclusion. When later presented in reverse, their arguments appear to be guided by broadly shared values even though their true origins stem from an isolated objective. In contrast to value-driven frameworks this approach is objective-driven; where you start with an outcome and then find values or facts that would best support landing on that objective. When our focus is on privately held objectives, professed values can be cycled through at convenience – with 'guiding' values cherry-picked based on their capacity to best promote a predetermined outcome.

Objective-Driven Framework



In objective-driven frameworks, values are approached as a means to accomplish an end. In a value-driven framework, it is the objective that changes based on where your facts and values point - with shared objectives requiring both shared facts and shared values to point the way. Since both frameworks may look similar when presented side-by-side, it helps to have other hallmarks that highlight when values have been chosen with a manipulative intent. As we look to our collective compass, we find one reliable indicator that anyone can be trained to spot from a young age: the frequent or deliberate use of logical fallacies.

When used aggressively, logical fallacies attack the structure of our reasoning to manipulate the conclusions that the unaware land on. Those proficient in wielding logical fallacies can make a lie appear true by targeting commonly held biases. Regardless of their policy solutions, everyone should have a basic understanding of how these attacks sabotage healthy conversations or we risk leaving our society vulnerable to mass exploitation. Simply put, if you don't know what an [ad hominem](#) or a [tu quoque](#) attack is, then it is very clear how to use that against you. If you can't spot a [strawman argument](#) or a [false dilemma fallacy](#) while they are happening in real time, then both can be wielded to reliably lead you to conclusions you wouldn't have otherwise supported. Being ignorant of a logical fallacy is what leaves you defenseless against its manipulations and the antidote is an awareness of how these techniques work. Only a few dozen [logical fallacies](#) cause the majority of our problems, and when enough of our society collectively learns to spot them as they happen, then we develop a form of herd immunity and they lose their manipulative sway. Games can be used to systemically teach large groups awareness of logical fallacies and I'll show early examples of this in chapter five.

Due to the ways they target our inherent vulnerabilities, logical fallacies are commonly spread by the innocent; if a lie sounds well-reasoned when you first learn it, it will also seem like the truth when you repeat it. Victims of these cognitive attacks may go on to emphatically repeat that lie as it was fed to them, while remaining completely unaware that they are building their arguments upon a cracked foundation that leaves them vulnerable to exploitation. Being a victim of abuse does not warrant shame – which can prevent the abused from recognizing how they were betrayed in the first place – and so the confused should be approached differently than those who wield logical fallacies with a predatory intent. In this vein, those who productively identify logical fallacies never use them to berate others or 'win' an argument, as much as explain why they're not yet having a healthy discussion. As we learn to spot those who repeatedly abuse logical fallacies to make their points or advance their interests, then we collectively see the crack in the illusion that attempts to pass off an objective-driven framework as value-driven. If someone earnestly seeks to share your solutions, then they will never have a need to use logical fallacies to manipulate you. So when we find the repeat offenders who intentionally exploit the vulnerabilities of others, it's their actions that have given them away no matter the values they claim. Even if their policies appear to be a mirror image to our own, if they are comfortable exploiting others to achieve their ends, then we know they don't belong. This prioritization of 'How' over 'What' is foundational to Empowered.Vote, personified by our compass that always seeks shared solutions. In the same ways shared evidence helps us find shared facts, logical fallacies illuminate values vulnerable to manipulation and highlight the separation of value-driven and objective-driven frameworks.

Now to identify the last nuance of my audience, let's bring our guiding question, 'Am I seeking a shareable solution?', to the third founding problem of Empowered.Vote: Civic Impotence. Which describes an inability for citizens to make a meaningful impact upon the trajectory of their government;

a sense of indifference that begins to calcify as a voter believes their voice doesn't adjust their Democracy.

I belong to a generation that witnessed more technological advances than every prior generation combined. From the way we order pizza to the way we trade stocks or stay connected across long distances, our technology has evolved to amplify us. But when I think back on the marvels that have been constructed in my lifetime, absent from the list of renovations is the way citizens impact their government. The way we vote, the way we debate, and the way we are represented feels frozen in the 1700's; ill-equipped to deal with the speed and demands of modern life.

As we look closer at this atrophy of impact on our Democracy, we can see that not everyone is equally concerned with the spread of Civic Impotence because not everyone feels unheard within our current setup. Collectively recognizing those that profit from our pollution and polarization is critical in us broadly understanding its origins. For many, disenfranchising voters is simply good business or just another aspect of effective politics. But this aim to reduce another's equitable access to Democracy wouldn't be broadly shared if its focus were inverted, so it's not a solution that could ever be embraced on our platform. Limiting another's equitable access to Democracy will never be a shareable solution.

Our desire to equitably empower all citizens is a foundational focus for Empowered.Vote, but this goal runs into conflict with the way power is encouraged to pool in a free market. It's at this intersection of Capitalism and Democracy that I believe we find the systemic source of our Civic Impotence.

In Capitalism, advertisements are bought and sold along an inverted demand curve – where the market is set based upon an ad's effectiveness to reach and influence rather than its manufacturing or development costs. Within a traditional demand curve, costs tend to diminish over time as inefficient processes get optimized. But in an inverted demand curve, as innovations make these techniques more effective, the costs for those services goes up instead of down, growing more valuable in their increased exclusivity. Even though it costs a television studio roughly the same amount of electricity to air a commercial at three in the morning as it does to air one at primetime or during the Super Bowl, the price of a commercial isn't set based on its expended electricity.

Learning to spot inverted markets is very useful when you look at civic designs and search for systemic sources of our inequity.

While humankind has been trading and selling goods for a very long time, the concept of Marketing as a focused profession has really only been around since the 1940's. At the time, it represented a shift in focus away from creating a product towards selling that product, not unlike the conditions that would give rise to Free-to-Play studios decades later. Companies saw great returns when they took advantage of a growing understanding of human psychology and then paired it with new far-reaching technologies

during an era of exponential population growth. These techniques were so effective at raising profits, that by the end of the 1940's, large marketing budgets had become expected line items for every corporation that sought to sell a good or service.

From gathering around the living room radio to the product placement between television commercials to micro-targeting users on social media based on an algorithm's capacity to effectively profile their vulnerabilities, as our advertising techniques have continued to evolve, the methods that reliably cut through the noise and amplify awareness of a specific product or topic are worth every penny to those with pockets deep enough to afford their expense. Due to the subtle nature of their influence, a commercial's impact isn't always fully understood by its target audience, where the intrusion can easily be dismissed as a distraction or small annoyance, if they're made aware at all. But since our ads are sold along an inverted demand curve, we just have to look at the skyrocketing prices of these techniques to understand what the market thinks the true value of their impact is worth.

This capitalistic approach towards purchasing persuasion runs into conflict with the goal of maintaining an equitable democracy. When a candidate's optimal path to get elected is to purchase commercials on the free market, it introduces foundational problems in the way our campaigns work. Commercials constrain our election conversations down to sound bites, lacking the accountability that comes with follow-up questions. As different citizens get exposed to different sets of commercials, our shared information becomes polluted and we stop recognizing or voting upon the same problems. In this environment, the candidate with the deepest coffers gets uneven access to the most influential techniques, using technology that our forefathers were not prepared for and so built no safeguards to prevent.

When the most effective way to achieve leadership in our country is to purchase propaganda, then fundraising becomes the lifeblood that campaigns depend upon. Without a steady stream of deep-pocketed donors to unlock access to the latest marketing techniques, most citizens cannot afford to run an effective campaign for public office. This Pay-to-Win approach in determining who is eligible to compete in our elections encourages our civic leaders to serve the needs of the donor class, structuring our government so that it solves their problems first. When we require wealth to get elected then our Democracy prioritizes the perspectives of the wealthy; leading us to increased inequality.

As we examine the design of our commercials, we find that they consistently leverage their brevity to exploit their target audience's biases. With only thirty seconds, there's not a lot of nuance that can be explained or retained, but there are many common biases that can be effectively exploited. From manufacturing a fear of missing out on a limited-time opportunity to anchoring expectations based on the way you present their options, the refinement of our various marketing tactics have been honed

over years of trial-and-error and will continue to evolve rapidly with the assistance of modern technology.

One of the most effective of these biases is also the simplest, the mere-exposure effect, which describes a person's tendency to prefer something that's familiar over something that is not. Understanding the impact of this effect explains why it can be so influential to flood our awareness with the same ad, even if that commercial barely mentions the brand and has no clear call to action. Merely being repeatedly exposed to an idea, product, or person makes that concept more palatable.

While these marketing techniques have been used to fuel Capitalism for decades, there are a subset of biases that have been uncovered which are consistently avoided by businesses that still tend to be very effective in influencing the outcome of political campaigns. They involve stoking our anger and fear to the point that we reach an exhausted and suggestible state. For example, if your goal is to sell soft drinks or deodorant, stoking hatred for the competition doesn't really help you sell more units and even has a chance of turning people off your product, altogether. But in an election, fostering hatred for your political opponent is extremely effective, especially when there are only two viable options. In those conditions, a candidate doesn't even need to propose solutions if they can prey upon the vulnerabilities of the polarized and remain the only other option. When we combine these anger-based marketing techniques that target political enemies with the mere-exposure effect, then we create an optimal path for campaign managers to flood our elections with advertisements that are designed to polarize and poison our civic discussions.

This bombardment of emotionally charged wedge issues leaves our electorate ill-equipped to govern; more exhausted from outrage than aware of the nuances of our available solutions. It's at this point, when we are repeatedly encouraged to give our endorsement while in an exhausted state, that internal alarm bells should be going off that we have been targeted for manipulation. Whatever the topic, it's the constant state of exhaustion that gives the game away. Whether its origins stem from anger, fear, or overwhelming complexity - when we are constantly exhausted then we become easier to manipulate.

Like logical fallacies, these marketing tactics that target our biases seek to exploit our cognitive blind spots. Due to the nature of the vulnerabilities they target, it can be difficult to spot this type of exhaustion occurring in our own lives without practice. Fortunately, there's a broadly recognized example that we can explore together: a terms-of-service agreement. That's the pop-up that you need to get past as you install most software. These 'agreements' are intentionally written at a level of complexity that requires both a specialized education and a great deal of time to decipher with confidence. This over-articulation of terms was designed to exhaust you with confusing legalese until you are overwhelmed; with most people not bothering to read the agreement as they scroll to the bottom. Then at the end of the terms, while in an exhausted state, you are given a false choice: where

you must accept all of their conditions – the ones you weren’t expected to read or understand - in order to proceed. This targeted amplification of our exhaustion followed by the presentation of a false choice is an extremely effective form of manipulation.

Once you learn to spot this ‘exhausted endorsement’ combo, it becomes a lot easier to see the same pattern play out in other systems you encounter. From filling out complex insurance forms to efficiently navigating tax preparation, we find artifacts that have been designed to overwhelm us to the point we endorse the path of least resistance. In these moments of weaponized exhaustion - where a topic has you throwing your hands up in anger or disgust or confusion - be mindful of those who follow after, pushing for you to make a false choice while you’re still in an unbalanced state. Again, it’s our shared compass that helps us see each other. Because those who earnestly seek to share your solutions will not want to keep you in a constant state of anger or fear or confusion. They may seek your support for problems that exhaust you both, but as you face those challenges, together, they will want to see you in an empowered state not an exhausted one.

When we primarily see our government through the distorted lens of our political tribes, then we pass our civic power on to those who run political parties and our ability to find shared solutions becomes beholden to their capacity to collaborate within a system that rewards their polarization. A democracy with only two parties doesn’t encourage our leaders to choose by your values, it forces you to choose between theirs. Those who lead political parties require less accountability when our values stop overlapping, so the optimal path for the candidate who does not seek shared solutions is to amplify our polarization in an effort to avoid their own accountability.

With each of our founding problems – Information Pollution, Political Polarization, and Civic Impotence – it’s the constant search for shared solutions that highlights who we are – that allows us to see each other, clearly, by our actions. This simple framework, to only look for solutions that are shared and try to support those who do the same, is what guides everything else; it sets the needle for our compass. Regardless of how complex our technology becomes, when we search for solutions that are intended to be shared by all, then the systems we craft will naturally seek to unite us.

So that’s who I’m looking for, those willing to put this shared compass first. If you decide that this second lens sounds like you, it doesn’t matter to me what your policies look like; you are the intended audience for this book.

And I could really use your help. In the following pages, I’ve written a rough first draft of a wide assortment of games, features, and social civic designs; the culmination of these different frameworks I refer to as Empowered.Vote.

I've approached the foundations of Empowered.Vote in ways familiar to me. For instance, at the start of a game's development a team typically wants to paper-prototype as much of the experience as possible. These iterations on paper are trivial in time and cost compared to iterations where engineers end up throwing out large chunks of code. Creating design summaries of different features helps facilitate these broader conversations around the details of the game before it's built and allows everyone involved to understand how the various systems are intended to interact with each other. Establishing these priorities first allows everyone to use shared values to iterate without needing nearly as much oversight to go in the right direction.

Eventually, engineers take their understanding of that paper design and write the code for an ugly first version. We call this rough, unbalanced, semi-playable shell of a game the Alpha build and it seeks a very specific type of playtester. Typically in games, your Alpha isn't shared externally beyond a small group of close friends and family because at this initial stage of development it helps to primarily get your candor from people who genuinely want you to succeed. They tend to be more willing to overlook a lack of polish and still want to give you their honest feedback about where the experience is headed. Just due to where you are in the process when they provide that feedback, the impact of your Alpha testers is often more pronounced than those who come after.

But while this approach works for games, the outsized impact of Alpha testers introduces some subtle problems as we apply it to the discovery of civic solutions. Ideally, from our very first feature onwards, it's not *my* friends and family that we should seek to appeal to, as I suspect they'd be inclined to share many of my blind spots. Instead, we need a framework that could be understood by everyone while owned by no one, so that we might all see each other clearly by our actions.

So as we explore these imperfect, unfinished designs, I ask that you look past the rough edges that will be polished through iterations and focus acutely on the values these frameworks are built upon. With value-driven designs, the values at the center are less likely to shift – while the tactics that seek to achieve these values will be in a constant state of iterative flux. Before our Pillars can set, I need to see if these values can be shared by everyone that would want us to succeed. So if you wish to explore Empowered.Vote as an Alpha tester, I ask that you use your own compass with a fierce scrutiny, searching for the reasons that a reasonable person wouldn't want to share our values. Or help us see why our tactics don't achieve our values; which is also extremely helpful feedback. But in both situations, it's the person looking for shared solutions that will guide the way.

Either through atrophy or trauma, some may find it a struggle to explore their values; their explorations inward as exhausting as my attempts to parse a Terms of Service agreement. For these people, I searched for a widely shared problem that anyone in the world could embrace from the same side. It was my search for this example that led me to the God of War and the First Mars Problem. I figured

that, no matter the color of your flag or skin, no one that was searching for a shared solution would want the world to end in a nuclear holocaust. When it comes to shared existential threats, we're all on the same team.

This perspective of the First Mars Problem anchored me as I sought to design systems that could be embraced by a vast spectrum of world views. Even when we are at our most divided and the pollution is so thick around our facts that we can't focus upon the same problems, with the First Mars Problem we always have an obvious place of shared ground to return to; where we might sincerely work to build our solutions together.



The Third Lens describes who we are building our solution for: a generation of colonists that will not know us. Before I describe the audience seen through this lens, I'd like to first explain the benefits of us collectively setting our sights so far beyond the horizon. The musings of the Second Mars Problem have less to do with a fascination for science-fiction and more to do with a distinguishable quirk that separates value-driven and objective-driven frameworks: Value-driven frameworks last a lot longer.

To highlight this delta, I'd like for us to design something together through a setup I call 'omnipotent succession'. For the sake of a thought-exercise, let's say you came across a person who could grant you the ability to see and correct every wrong in the world with just a thought, the essence of being fully empowered. But there are two constraints in our game:

1. When you die at the end of your natural life, you will need to pass this power of omnipotence on to someone else. As that person dies, they will need to select their successor, and they the next, and so forth until we land on a successor that is perverted enough to use their abilities to primarily suppress instead of empower.

2. Your score is not simply determined by the wrongs you make right in your life-time, but for every right and wrong that your bestowed omnipotence would one day get used to reinforce.

Within this setup, what frameworks might you build for choosing your successor? What safeguards would you put in place to protect your gift of omnipotence from spoiling as it passed from one generation to the next? This work begins alone; I'd encourage you to reflect on your own omnipotent succession plan and land on some specific qualifications. Even when you find inspiration elsewhere, it helps to go back and re-articulate this in your own words.

When I first tried to solve for problems that would arise many generations out, one thing that struck me was that after a certain point in the future, I primarily needed to use value-driven frameworks to guide the way. Objective-driven frameworks, particularly those guided by privately held objectives, tend to have an expiration date of around a generation or two. At that point, either the objective is accomplished or, since it wasn't broadly shared, there's no one left to take up the mantle for that cause and the objective dies with the people who last held it. In contrast, when we create our solutions in ways that are guided by shared values, then those designs tend to be very resilient as they pass from one generation to the next.

Since both objective-driven and value-driven frameworks can outlast our lifetime, they may at first appear to be equitably evergreen. But as we compare both frameworks generations into the future, we can see that when privately-held objectives eventually falter, shared values continue to keep working. A king's royal decree will create an objective-driven framework that lasts until the next king comes along and decides to replace it. But a value-driven framework is guided by an arbiter found within us, like asking us to treat others the way we wish to be treated, and so these framings continue to provide very similar guidance even thousands of years later.

I leveraged this naturally occurring delta in the longevity between objective-driven and value-driven frameworks to constrain our focus upon only building value-driven solutions that would be able to last, indefinitely. By primarily designing Empowered.Vote for an audience that arrives generations after us, we make it very difficult for the corruption of self-serving goals to take root as we lay the foundations for their new Democracy. We may iterate on our systems with the problems we find today, but we build our solutions, primarily, for those who will come tomorrow. Initially, this may seem an odd point of focus, to look so far into the future while our present polarization is so deafening. But much like the First Mars Problem, there's a grounding benefit in us putting our guiding focus upon a problem that we can all share. And by collectively designing a modern Democracy before it is needed, we give ourselves at least a generation to iterate on our boat before it must be seaworthy.

I refer to the colonists that will first use our platform in its 'delivered' state, generations out, as the Omegas. In order to describe this Third Lens and the ways I expect the Omegas to interact with Empowered.Vote, let's return to the three problems of the first chapter that we used to define the Alphas: Information Pollution, Political Polarization, and Civic Impotence. Empowered.Vote solves each of these guiding problems through a series of value-driven frameworks, leveraging broadly shared values that we expect to remain as true for the Omegas as they are for the Alphas. As we explore various frameworks through this Third Lens, we can assume the Alpha's portion of the work is complete and describe how various features will interconnect once they are in their delivered state. To highlight these connections, I'll briefly summarize features here that we will return to in the fifth chapter to explore in more depth.

Let's start with the Omega's search for shared facts. Our generation learned the hard way what happens when the pollution around our information becomes amplified by technology, with any discussion of facts bringing with it the immediate next question: Whose facts are you going to be using? As if there were a buffet of truths to choose from. In this environment, how might the Omegas collectively understand which of their facts are indeed even facts?

For example, let's say we were both in a room together when a pair of strangers entered, each with a conflicting story about the weather outside – one saying it was raining and the other that it was sunny. In that situation, what might the two of us do to determine the truth of the matter? I suspect we wouldn't want to just guess between the strangers and then go about our days. Nor would we decide based on which person had spoken first or the loudest... No, all things being equal, we'd probably just go outside and look for ourselves. And when we returned, we would remember who had been telling us what.

Having a collective memory of who said what and a shared understanding of how that turned out is how we begin to find shared facts.

Creating various systems that bring accountability to our sources of information is a reoccurring theme throughout Empowered.Vote. Having authenticated accounts associated with each piece of information creates a digital paper trail, making it easier to collectively recognize our sources of disinformation. For many of the same reasons our financial institutions assign each person a credit rating, we develop transparent frameworks that remember the credibility of all of our sources of information. And if the Omegas find their facts are in conflict with another's, they can show their support through an investment on the Awareness Exchange; a stock market simulator that approaches facts as bonds and solutions as stocks.

Each person with an authenticated account is given a stipend of Empowered Gems on a set cadence. This imaginary currency is never sold, has a memory of where it's been, and represents an equal

distribution of civic influence. When the Omegas disagree on their facts, they're able to invest a portion of their Empowered Gems upon the Awareness Exchange and are rewarded if other evidence later validates that fact.

As time passes, evidence accumulates, and our collective understanding of our facts solidifies towards certainty, the players who correctly invested in supporting that fact's authenticity will see a return on their investment. The Awareness Exchange gives the Omegas a shared record to clearly identify those who repeatedly support facts that are later validated. This game also provides a system of accountability, highlighting those who continuously vouch for facts that end up crumbling under further scrutiny.

When our primary filter for determining a 'fact' comes at the start of the conversation, then whoever holds that filter gets to determine our foundations of understanding. This represents a problematic pooling of power that leaves an evergreen platform vulnerable to a generation that wields their filter for their own advantages. It can't be whose facts we choose, because then we no longer look for shared problems or seek to find shared solutions. We need our filter at the end of our understanding, not the beginning. We need a way to collectively remember, with the wisdom and clarity of hindsight, when we made the right decisions and when we didn't so we can judge history's advocates with matching transparency. To accomplish this, we need to leave the Omegas with a better framework for recognizing the credibility of their collective evidence.

If we were to imagine the totality of information as a funnel with everything that anyone had first proposed as a 'fact' – including the most preposterous of conspiracy theories – entering the funnel at the wide end. And then over time, as we watched our 'facts' conflict and get rejected with scrutiny and new information, our funnel narrows into a subset of information that is more confidently trusted. With a '10' representing a highly contested claim, while at the other end of the spectrum as we get closer to a '1' on our scale, we find the type of facts that are widely supported by evidence and repeatedly reinforced.

With this Credibility Scale identified, it makes it easier to articulate the degree of confidence that we share in our facts, facilitating precise understanding about where, when, and why we disagree. Clearly identifying our collective confidence in our facts ensures that we approach our problems with similar degrees of nuance and uncertainty. It's only when we sincerely try to solve the same problems, that our collective values will point us towards shared solutions.

But while identifying shared evidence is a critical first step towards recognizing shared facts, as we target the needs of that entire colony it becomes apparent that sharing evidence will only get them part of the way to sharing clarity. For instance, sharing evidence doesn't address the intended pollution of a Terms of Service agreement nor help the broader public navigate the nuances of parliamentary

procedure. When only lawyers are able to follow the intricacies of our laws, then it will only be lawyers with the capacity to govern our Democracy with nuance. Since we wish to leave the Omegas a government that will indefinitely serve them all - and not just their lawyers - we must strive to keep every corner of their Democracy universally understood, building frameworks that create clarity around their problems, values, and solutions.

As a game developer, I tend to approach the problem of maintaining public awareness in a Democracy as a matter of engagement; believing our civic responsibilities must remain as engaging as their surrounding environment. A generation that loses interest in their responsibilities as citizens isn't going to have a government that adheres to their interests for very long.

I designed simple games that I thought might help the same set of facts appeal to a broad set of people. Trivia games that play like game shows while celebrating awareness of civic problems on a local, national, and global level. Interactive graphs that show citizens where their tax dollars are being spent in a way that's easily shared and compelling to explore.

Or Empowered Badges, that function like merit badges from scouts or unlocking achievements in massively multiplayer games. But instead of showing proficiency in woodworking or wilderness survival, Empowered Badges establish a shared understanding of civic issues. Each badge has a shifting rating on the Credibility Scale where its authenticity can be endorsed or contested with an investment of Empowered Gems.

These badges can also function as a 'key' to join discussions happening elsewhere on Empowered.Vote; allowing the Omegas to isolate their facts before exploring their values. When we keep these discussions separate, it protects our conversations from a large subset of logical fallacies that target common vulnerabilities in our shared understanding. We can't be guided by our values when we do not share the same facts. Even on issues where our values align perfectly, if we use different facts then we would still land on different solutions.

Empowered Badges leave the Omegas with a framework to focus upon the same problems. And when their facts are in dispute, it allows both parties to have parallel conversations, where each discussion is governed by a different badge – in essence, two conflicting sets of facts. They can then explore both scenarios, understanding their collective values with greater nuance as their agreed upon sets of facts change between the two Badges. This process helps to reduce the potency of our misunderstandings. And by placing each Empowered Badge on the Awareness Exchange, we give the Omegas a way to invest in the credibility of their contested sets of facts, scrutinizing the veracity of each of their badges and their authors, indefinitely.

But even if we leave the Omegas with engaging frameworks to discover shared evidence, there is still the problem of how that information gets compiled, summarized, and editorialized before it reaches them. So beyond their facts being evidence-based and engaging, we also seek to make the Omega's information as anti-partisan as possible. Being anti-partisan is different than being non-partisan.

A non-partisan approach seeks to avoid offending everyone, steering clear of polarizing issues, always searching to find a harmonizing middle ground between opposing perspectives. While that objective is enticing, the vulnerability here is that it creates a reactive approach to our conflicts, effectively allowing others to establish your stance on that issue. In a polarized environment where one or both sides no longer seek a shared solution with the other, the non-partisan's desire to cling to the middle ground can be exploited by embracing radical positions that shift the 'middle ground' of that issue far in either direction.

In contrast, an *anti*-partisan approach focuses on removing the impact that political parties have in determining the way we frame our information. The tricks of tribalism have a seductive impact on the unaware; before we can spot this problem within the safety of our own political party, it may be easier to notice in the way we approach professional sports.

There have always been world-class athletes just by nature of the qualifier, but before the 1950's, a sustainable business in sports usually relied upon ticket sales or gambling to stay afloat. In order to make ends meet, teams had to pay their players so little that most would still need to find another job during the off-season. It was possible to make a living as an athlete, but it was kinda like performing in regional theater or joining the circus, it wasn't really associated with having a lucrative lifestyle. You could go back a very long time and even adjusting for inflation we would struggle to find athletes that were paid anywhere close to as much as they are now.

This is because the primary business model for professional sports changed about a generation back, from selling tickets to advertisements. By the end of the 1940's, commercials were broadly approached as a justifiable business expense. As their demand boomed, the hunt was on for the perfect place to showcase these forgettable moments of propaganda. It made sense to everyone involved that a billboard placed above Times Square would influence more potential customers than the one placed along some desolate road; so different rates would be charged for each location. Providing varied options for companies to showcase their ads led to a focus on understanding and categorizing the motivations of the people living in those markets, so much so that the terms 'advertising' and 'marketing' have practically become synonymous. Marketing executives found that it wasn't just the number of eyes that reached the ad that mattered, but whose. If you were selling a toy and wanted to market it to kids, you might put your ad in the back of a comic book or create a commercial to play during Saturday morning cartoons. If you were trying to sell nylons or make-up, you'd want to purchase

ad space that played during the day, when it was expected that kids were at school and men were still at work. But when it came to the projected purchasing power of different demographics, most companies would seek to put their advertisements in front of young to middle-aged men. Activities that could consistently capture the focus of this prized demographic – such as watching professional sports - became valuable markets for companies to compete over. And so the prices of their ‘advertisement slots’ went up with the increased demand.

As fans shout along with the roar of the crowd, it creates a visceral sense of communal belonging rarely found in modern life. By tapping into our most satisfying tribal tendencies, it allows fans to celebrate and commiserate in unison, leaving behind a deep connection to those wearing the same jersey.

Fostering rivalries and a fierce loyalty for their team created fans that were eager to return game-after-game and willing to sit through a barrage of advertisements while remaining in an elated state. This combination proved to be very valuable to marketing executives. Companies that were looking to showcase their products found greater returns when presenting their advertisements to an arena of enthralled fans than pretty much any other place they could find. As owning a team became increasingly profitable, players sought a portion of those earnings, with most professional sports today having some form of guaranteed revenue sharing at around 50% for both the owners and players. This gives an explanation – not a justification – for athletes living for centuries at one pay bracket, where they might make what would amount today as a few thousand dollars a game and then, over the course of just one generation, become one of the most lucrative professions possible, with some players making hundreds of millions of dollars in salary. That’s a pretty big swing for a market that barely even existed two generations back. The wealth inequality that is created from marketing propaganda can be difficult to recognize when personified through the salary of your favorite player. But from the perspective of playing a city simulator, a society could afford a lot of teachers and doctors and firemen with the hundred million dollars we pay for one athlete. It’s an odd thing to have witnessed in my life such explosive growth in player salaries while watching our schools close sports programs due to lack of funds.

When we love our teams with a passionate fervor it can distort our perspectives, making it difficult to see the same problems. That’s what makes tapping into the motivated reasoning of our tribalism so potent, the communal blind spots this process creates and exploits.

Imagine for a moment, sitting in a stadium watching your favorite team playing in the last game of the season. And in the final minutes with the score tied, the referee makes a tight call. In that moment, the stadium erupts, with all the fans from the Home team outraged; loudly, passionately disagreeing with the call. And all the fans for other team believe in their heart that the ref got the call right. Keep in mind, each person in the stadium bore witness to the same set of facts, they all saw the same play, but

due to the blinding objective of their team winning, it made it difficult for everyone to see what happened with shared clarity.

Wearing 'rose-colored glasses' is a common problem when we approach our facts through the framing of our tribe winning or losing.

While this quirk in our tribal thinking is problematic in our sports, a refusal to recognize the same facts outside of the lens of our political parties is lethal to a Democracy. Because we leave ourselves no shared ground to build upon. Whether it's the Alphas or the Omegas, when our society doesn't observe the same facts then we won't be looking to solve the same problems and the solutions we collectively point towards become scattered and fragmented. So we prioritize anti-partisanship, and commit to each other to try to remove the distortions of rose-colored glasses and speak for ourselves, avoiding the vulnerabilities inherent in tribal groupthink.

Anti-partisanship is embraced throughout our platform because it ensures our focus remains on policy at the expense of politics; where we support citizens and candidates but not their political parties. Empowered.Vote is not a third option between being a Liberal or a Conservative as much as a new way to amplify the impact of all citizens that are seeking shared solutions, whether they approach their answers as liberal, conservative, or something uniquely their own.

To see how this value of anti-partisanship manifests as a feature for the Omegas, I would start with 'Read & Rank', which was designed to put the interests of voters ahead of their party leaders. Every election cycle, candidates are given a quick questionnaire that asks how they feel about a variety of civic problems. Voters then say which responses they align with and rank their favorite answers, but they're not told which candidate said what until after the survey is over. In this way, we constrain the voter's focus upon the contents of their candidates' solutions, before they fix upon the identities of their options. Systemically, it should be the voter's perspective that matters more than the candidate's.

We also seek to create greater awareness around common vulnerabilities in our logic, as their exploitation leads to an extremely effective form of manipulation. Due to the vulnerabilities that logical fallacies target, it can be very difficult to recognize their abuse happening in real time without practice. 'Fallacy Finders' creates a productive and safe environment where players can learn to spot these manipulative attacks while amongst friends. It plays a lot like bar trivia or many online games, where everyone in earshot is on the same team, but your team might be competing against other groups, elsewhere. By creating a framework that allows you to 'protect' your teammates from logical fallacies, these moments of awareness bring pride instead of the shame or ridicule often associated with their discovery; both of which inhibit learning.

At the start of a match, each player is assigned a logical fallacy to protect against. Then as a group, your team watches a conversation on a civic topic. Anytime a player spots the fallacy they're assigned, they press their button, with the teams that press their button earlier getting a bonus. Every 10-15 minutes, the various fallacies the players protect against get shuffled. This means the optimal play is to call out to your teammates every fallacy you see, even if it's not one you're currently assigned. This creates an environment where the people you trust protect you from the tactics that exploit your trust. As players become more proficient at spotting these manipulations in our public conversations, it creates a form of herd immunity that protects them against these types of exploitations creeping into their own conversations.

Anyone that is seeking a shared solution will not need to leverage logical fallacies to manipulate others.

Getting the Omegas to recognize Shared Facts is the first step, but it only represents part of the journey. Even if we left them with frameworks that provided complete alignment in their understanding, by virtue of being different people with unique perspectives and experiences, there would remain opportunities for them to sincerely disagree about their values. Facilitating conversations that productively unpack our unique priorities on a topic leads us to a very different set of tasks than ensuring our information is accurate and shareable. As we shift our focus from finding shared facts to unpacking shared values, the central problem we address shifts from Information Pollution to Political Polarization.

The inherent danger in embracing values that we know are not widely shared is that it leads us to solutions found at the expense of others. In order to build frameworks that help the Omegas productively explore their values, Empowered.Vote leverages mediation techniques developed in the behavioral sciences. If two couples were having problems with their marriage, and the first was going to see a marriage counselor and the second wasn't, I suspect smart money would be on those seeking additional help. While most counselors would tell you that every couple they see is unique, they'd probably also say that most of the problems that they come across in relationships tend to happen along a handful of predictable patterns that involve breakdowns in communication. If the counselor can spot the pattern that's occurring, they can help the couple to unpack that problem productively and then teach them how to create guardrails so that it's easier for them to spot when the pattern re-emerges – even when the counselor isn't there.

In order to create the optimal opportunity for these conversations to be productive, much care has been taken in crafting the environments where they take place. For the same reasons it's unproductive when someone floods our conversations with facts that they know aren't true, it's not helpful when someone hides under the cover of anonymity to promote values that they don't sincerely embrace. When anyone claims a value that doesn't align with their actions, then that's usually a pretty good indication that the

value they proclaimed is not sincerely held. We require authenticated accounts to engage with others on Empowered.Vote as it ensures that each participant has only one voice in our conversations, unaided by an army of chat bots attached to anonymous email addresses. Once their account has been Connected, we place each person within a series of communities to support their civic explorations.

The first is called 'Civil Civics' and it was designed to help people who are in the same geographic location address local problems. With authenticated accounts, we can ensure that only the people who live in that specific area are able to join these conversations, creating a protected 'walled garden' for communities to explore their collective civic concerns, without the distortions of those who live outside that community. When searching for shareable solutions, there are substantial benefits of accountability that stem from conversations where the participants are familiar with each other. Limiting the size of our communities helps us foster that familiarity.

Our forefathers created a democracy for 2.5 million people that were spread across 13 colonies. The ratio of citizens to Representatives was fiercely debated during the Constitutional Convention, and was among the last alterations they made before finalizing the document. Our founders had feared that the ratio of 40,000 citizens per Representative would leave the people without an adequate voice in their new government and, after George Washington weighed in, they unanimously decided upon 30,000 citizens per Representative. This led to two chambers to craft legislation: an 'upper body' that would always contain two Senators per state, and a 'lower body' that would grow with the population of our country, with the number of Representatives starting at 59. Over time, the population of our young nation grew and the number of Representatives went up. By 1929, the same group of legislators that laid the foundations for the Great Depression decided to indefinitely cap the total number of Representatives at 435, regardless of how large each district grew in population. This decision preserved the waning power of Representatives – one Representative among 59 has far more influence than one among 435 - but it came at the expense of those they led.

Almost a century after that decision, the population of the United States has tripled but the number of Representatives has stayed at 435. There are now 330 million Americans spread across 50 States, with roughly one Representative for every 700,000 people. The ratio of our 'representation' shrinks every year that our population increases, leading to a Democracy that systemically pays less attention to the individual concerns of its citizens.

As we look to foster stronger connections between the Omegas and lay the foundations for a modern democracy, we should create communities that support each district and state, but we should also design a system that can scale to accommodate the needs of those citizens more gracefully. As we shift our focus from local concerns towards national and global issues, instead of placing every person within

one large conversation where only a few voices are able to be heard, we leverage our technology to facilitate smaller discussions where more perspectives can be explored in familiarity.

The 'Symposium' is designed to help us productively unpack our values through smaller conversations; it functions a lot like a speech and debate tournament held online, where contestants are only asked to defend the perspectives they embrace. Symposiums take a deep dive on a single civic topic over the course of six weeks, with Connected Accounts determining which perspectives advance to the next round. Those who wish to be civic leaders debate their values on a topic until they have alignment and only then debate their solutions. Once they land on a policy that they believe best serves their values, they collectively make some predictions; called shots as to what metrics they would judge the success or failure of their proposed solution. These solutions are placed on the Awareness Exchange alongside their success/fail criteria, allowing those who followed along with that Symposium to endorse the solutions they heard with an investment of Empowered Gems. If that solution is ever enacted, their criteria represent clear milestones that will cause an investment of Empowered Gems to 'payout', returning greater dividends of civic credibility the earlier that solution was endorsed.

- In the same way special interests write both the first and final drafts of our bills, we create a way for the public to transparently craft our legislative solutions.
- As our ancestors were tasked with building us a democracy with the best tools they have available, so must we – for all of those that come after us.

3 how



Empowered.Vote is an online platform designed to empower civic engagement. We leverage value-based designs because having aligned values allows large groups to move with extraordinary efficiency on large problems; the kind our generation will soon face.

The core tenet of Empowered.Vote is that shared solutions last the longest because they benefit everyone for the same reason. No manipulation or coercion is necessary when we both earnestly want the same thing.

The second tenet – built in service of the first – is that in order to find shared solutions, we must focus on a problem that we both truly share.

And the third tenet: Before we can see the same problems or share our solutions, foundationally, we must see our facts with a shared clarity.

In essence:

In order for our solutions to last, we need to solve shared problems while using shared facts.

In search of these three points, I divided Empowered.Vote into three sections; each focused on a different problem – and so each was also designed with a different target audience in mind. In response to my three buckets of grievances I built the three pillars of Empowered.Vote.



The Inform Pillar was built in response to information pollution. Since everyone is affected by information pollution, for us to be able to reach our intended audience, the features from this first pillar need to target ‘everyone’. Which is more confining than it initially sounds. Because we can’t just appeal to everyone that already agrees with us – we need a platform where *everyone* feels the information being provided is earnest and accurate.

To do this systemically, we use value-based system designs to ensure our information is always three things: evidence-based, engaging, and anti-partisan. Features built from this pillar tend to use a lot of game development techniques to help the same set of facts appeal to as broad an audience as possible.

We leave the interpretation of these facts – the analysis, conclusions and the punditry – to the conversations of the other pillars. The overall goal of the Inform Pillar is not to change anyone’s mind, but to provide a set of tools so that we can all see the same problems.



The Connect Pillar was built to oppose Political Polarization. It takes the problems that we find in the Inform Pillar and helps us to unpack them productively with each other. Since not everyone is looking to find shared problems or solutions, this second pillar is intended to have a smaller audience than the first.

Starting with the Connect Pillar, we protect our conversations from anonymity by utilizing authenticated accounts to ensure each person has only one voice in our discussions. When it comes to structuring these conversations, we take fewer design cues from the anonymous corners of the internet and more guidance from successful dating websites that ask you about your values and then try to pair you up with a lasting match.

For topics that tend to be more volatile, the Connect Pillar leverages many of the same mediation techniques used by therapists and counselors applied at scale to build stronger connections between the members of a community. Here we focus our evolving understanding of the behavioral sciences to systemically unpack what each of us value in our solutions.

The thinking being, that if you take two people who disagree on 90% of things, they're going to have a hard time finding the common ground necessary to find shared solutions – even if you tell them what they agree on ahead of time. Conversely, if you take two people who see nearly everything the same, and then you ask that second couple to chat about something that they disagree about... I find this latter group has a better shot at landing on a shared solution because starting from a place of mutual respect goes a long way in helping people evolve their perspectives.

So that's the focus of the features in the second pillar. We build tools that systemically help people find productive conversations. And then we structure it so that our collective values guide the tactics of building our solutions.

All of this is in service of a belief that beyond the first Mars Problem, our lasting solutions are found – not when it is you versus me – but when it is us versus a shared problem.



The Empower Pillar was built in response to civic impotence; it leverages technology to equitably empower the citizens of a democracy. It takes the collective priorities unpacked in the Connect Pillar and then it transparently turns those into tactics that make a tangible impact on our communities.

While anyone with a Connected Account may freely join the Empower Pillar, the features here are specifically designed to support Civic Leaders; volunteers looking to find like-minded people or those wishing to run for public office.

Due to our civic focus, before you can engage with others anywhere on Empowered.Vote you must first Connect your account by verifying your identity. Other than that authentication, you control what you share about who you are and your policy decisions in very much the same way you might now; at your discretion.

But if a person with a Connected Account decides to Empower their account, their private policy stances become public. Empowered Accounts are then sorted in a way that makes it easier for everyone to find like-minded civic leaders. The ones that see the same solutions to the problems that each of us are most focused on solving.

By matching elected leaders up with what you prioritize – instead of the other way around – it allows for more accurate democratic representation. It is this nuance of our citizens' choices that we aim to amplify instead of the power pooled by our politicians.

At Empowered.Vote, we encourage our members to determine their own stances on civic issues on a case-by-case basis. How you vote outside our platform will always remain your decision – we operate as an independent layer to support citizens within their democracy. It is the goal of this layer to remove the strangled grip that wedge issues and political parties have on productive discussions by approaching independent issues as if they were truly independent.

We must remove the ability for a wedge issue like abortion to influence an unrelated issue like the distribution of our tax burden. Currently, if I wish to influence the latter, my smartest money isn't spent

broadly espousing the benefits of a different tax code. Instead, it's spent making the right people passionately upset about a separate wedge issue that will galvanize their support into a polarized state – making them blind with passion and easy to manipulate.

But when we untangle unrelated issues, we create the space to search for shared solutions; if not here then elsewhere. Because no one should be forced to change their stance on a wedge issue in order to think independently about other civic problems that are facing us.

That's the focus of features from the Empower Pillar – we use modern technology to empower the civic impact of those seeking shared solutions.

We find the facts and values that we sincerely share, and then only build our solutions upon those places of shared alignment.

Throughout our platform, our focus is less on what you believe and more on how you acquire and express that belief. Where the Inform Pillar focuses on preserving the past, the Connect Pillar focuses on preserving the present, and the Empower Pillar focuses on preserving our shared future.

4 priorities

As a framework, Game Theory relies on simple, value-based games to understand how people tend to react in different situations. When we are able to do this repeatedly across a large enough slice of people that is proportionally representative of the whole, then we can extrapolate those responses out to better understand what the broader community values. Since Empowered.Vote is a platform that seeks to be guided by the values of its community, having clear, shareable frameworks that help us understand our collective values with precision is extremely useful.

Among the more famous experiments in Game Theory is the Prisoner's Dilemma, which involves two players pretending to be accomplices in a botched robbery. In its setup, you get isolated from your partner and you both are given the same choice: Either cooperate with the authorities or don't.

- If you both cooperate, you both are imprisoned for two years.
- If neither cooperates, you both are imprisoned for one year.
- If one of you cooperates and the other doesn't, then the helpful accomplice will go free and the one that chose not to cooperate will be imprisoned for seven years.

This game that is solved by a single binary question – to cooperate or not – teaches us a lot about how and when people choose to trust others and the natural limits of that trust. It allows us to study with specificity the factors that can improve or inhibit that connection.

Once you have a baseline of how people respond to a certain problem, you can make slight tweaks to a surrounding variable and determine how much each variation matters to the overall equation. How much do the percentages of distribution change when we change the length of each prison sentence? Does it matter if the prisoners are male or female? Educated or self-taught? Religious? Do they change their behavior based on how much money they have in their bank account? By using simple games to understand what we each collectively value, we can see with clarity what our communal values look like and what specifically makes them shift.

Back in the 1950's, a variation of the Prisoner's Dilemma was discovered that predicted how frequently people would seek to cooperate: It mattered significantly whether the dilemma was presented to the

players as a 'one-off' or 'iterative' exchange. When the game was considered a one-off and the players believed they would never interact with that partner again, then collectively the players were more inclined to betray their partner. But when they were told the experiment was going to be iterative – or that they would be playing multiple rounds against the same person – the trust they collectively showed in each other shot way up.

When I first uncovered this experiment it immediately resonated with me, giving voice to something I'd long struggled to articulate. I'd spent the first half of my life growing up in small towns with the other half living in America's largest cities, and like the countless generations before me who'd made a similar trek, I was struck by the differences between those two worlds. In the less populated communities of my youth, whenever I'd meet a stranger, I knew there was a decent chance I'd end up seeing them again; small towns are like that. When everyone knows everyone, it endows that community with many of the same benefits of trust discovered in the iterative version of the Prisoner's Dilemma.

As I transitioned to city life, I found wisdom in its diverse perspectives, safety within a more robust civic safety net, and yet something heartfelt was missing. In more densely populated areas, each stranger you encounter is bound to remain strange to you, indefinitely. And over time, the one-off nature of these interactions begins to resemble the more jaded approach of a one-off Prisoner's Dilemma.

Understanding when our relationships are one-off or iterative goes a long way in predicting when our social systems are going to have breakdowns in trust or where those systems are going to be more vulnerable to a targeted assault.

This vulnerability brings us back to our modern technologies and the challenges unique to our generation. In its earliest iterations, the Internet has primarily been an unceasing exploration in one-off interpersonal exchanges. Whether it's conflict in a game or an online forum, our modern social infrastructures provide the freedom to be an unrelenting asshole – giving social permission to say things that you would never say to a person standing in front of you. And since the victim won't be in the next game or in the next conversation, the standard social safeguards that would normally help reset this behavior don't apply.

As we look to the challenges that the Omegas will face, this idea of creating communities that breed familiarity is one that we should return to frequently. Iterative communities – where our actions have an impact on the ones that know us – breed communal trust.

But an understanding of Game Theory is helpful beyond the Prisoner's Dilemma because the ability for these simple games to decipher and anticipate our values can also be turned against us without our awareness. For most of Game Theory's existence, its discoveries could only be uncovered through the laborious process of rigid experimentation. These iterations developed slowly, confined to the

explorations and musings of academia, since even simple games still needed to be run consistently and with strict protocols to be broadly credible or helpful.

But technology has now changed this requirement, drastically reducing the resources to develop new games and uncover more nuanced values. Our computers are plentiful, extremely consistent in their approach, adhere perfectly to protocols, and provide the impartiality necessary to be broadly helpful. What's more, with the rise of surveillance capitalism, you can identify and conduct countless experiments on members without them even knowing, in many ways, understanding their values better than they do. Using the same behavioral data that our private social media companies sell to hostile foreign governments, we can run a near infinite amount of games on our country's population and understand with high accuracy what our collective values look like and when those values are most vulnerable to manipulation.

So while Game Theory is a powerful tool that helps us identify and articulate our collective values, we still need evergreen safeguards in place to protect ourselves against its misuse and make sure its discoveries always support the common good.

To do that, we need value-driven designs.



I learned of Game Theory as an adult, but I first learned of value-driven designs when I was a boy. Though back then, I just thought of it as my mom's cake trick.

See when we were growing up, my little sister and I would often want the same thing – like the last piece of cake. And so what my dad would do, is he'd walk in and split that piece right down the middle; give us both half. But it never failed, one of us always felt slighted. Either my sister's piece was too big or my slice had more frosting or hers had the better tasting color of frosting... it'd drive my dad crazy.

My mom, though, she always knew how to bring our values into play; help us find productive priorities. So what she would do is she'd hand me the knife, and have me cut that last piece in two wherever I wanted. But then after I was done cutting, she would let my little sister choose her piece first.

So while I was the one who had the agency to choose where to cut, my optimal play was now to make my cut as close to equal as possible because I knew, whatever she decided, I would get the second

piece. But that also meant that if I could figure out what flavor icing my sister wanted more than me, she may be persuaded to give me a slightly larger slice and we both leave happier.

My goals had shifted; by focusing on what we both valued, my mom had built us a framework so that we could reliably and repeatedly find shared problems – even when she wasn't there. Where before our efforts centered around amplifying to our father the distorted imperfections of the piece we had been left with, it was now a shared goal for me to understand what my sister wanted. I instinctively stopped and discussed with her right before the cut so that there were no surprises for either of us afterwards.

Where my dad had tried to solve our problem, my mom had solved our process.

As I grew older, I'd continue to marvel at my mom's cake trick. For one, I found it also worked on a lot of things that weren't cake. It scaled incredibly well – I could apply it to huge or trivial decisions with both loved ones and strangers to help us find a shared problem. I'd find traces of it in other designs, eventually spotting it in systems that would predate my mom by centuries, but I would always see it as her cake trick; where when you have two parties, one distributes transparently while the other chooses their share first.

This distribution of agency creates a systematic check on both parties that dynamically keeps them seeking balance with each other. Constraining power in this way is found at the center of even the most ancient of our Democracies: Where the ones who rule are intended to be bound in service to those who do not.

But her cake trick taught me something beyond checks and balances that I didn't realize until much later in life. While both my mom and our forefathers had divided power in their designs, it was only her framing that repeatedly forced the search for a shared problem.

So when I saw our forefather's democracy begin to fissure under modern pressures, it was my mom's cake trick that started my search for a system of shareable values that would fix it.

I sought to work with our shared values but found them an inconsistent and perverted mess. When there's no shared foundation of reality or accountability, a society can't be guided by its values. So to ensure Empowered.Vote always pursues shared values, I entrenched our focus along our three pillars.

The Inform Pillar incentivizes the search for shared facts to find shared problems. The Connect Pillar takes those shared problems and collectively finds what everyone values in a solution. Then the Empower Pillar iterates on that solution, indefinitely, as new information becomes available. When these conversations are clearly separated out, it makes each more productive because each has a very different goal that it targets.

If we are talking about *facts*, that's a very binary conversation. We either believe something is true or we don't. When we are unsure, our goal should be to find clarity based upon shared evidence. The Inform Pillar seeks that clarity so we can see the same problems.

But once we recognize the same problem and we begin breaking down what we *value* in a solution, then those conversations are not binary at all; a person's values tend to be very personal, so we took a focused approach in unpacking that nuance, productively. The Connect Pillar seeks to understand our collective values so they can be what guide us.

And with just these two points – our facts and our values – we can determine a lot. When they're both accurately aligned, no matter the problem, they allow us to see a trajectory of what every solution should look like. When we *accurately* share our facts and values, they always point towards shared solutions.

But on a long enough timeline, this power to determine our solutions makes both our facts and values vulnerable to a targeted assault. The problem with only having two points in a line, is that you have no way to validate if you got your points right. This quest for accountability in both our facts and values necessitated us seeking a third point.

So as we turn to *implement* what we value, our conversations again become very binary and transparent. Since we've already identified what we care the most about, the focus here is primarily tactical and the discussions are no longer centered around whether or not we should do something, but rather how our solutions might accomplish our values optimally based on the best information we have available. The goal of the Empower Pillar is to isolate our solutions so they can be seen by everyone with shared transparency.

These three points – a topic's facts, values, and solutions – will always naturally gravitate towards alignment with each other. When they are clearly identified, we have the means to build systems where any two points can be used to see if the third is in alignment. Giving us a framework to know our leaders – not just by their words – but by their solutions.

5 what

Now for the roadmap; I'll introduce our features along our three pillars.



Inform

The Inform Pillar was built upon three core beliefs:

- Facts should be supported by evidence.
- Information should be engaging.
- Our approach should be anti-partisan.

While all features in the Inform Pillar should be welcoming to a broad audience, we find that many people like to learn in different ways, so our tactics respect this reality. We provide the same information to everyone, but we vary our educational methods based on our evolving understanding of our target audience, with the goal to provide something for everyone. Some might be visual learners; others might prefer to read or listen to stay informed. We provide different levels of granularity, too, as many people only have time for a quick summary of civic issues – while most will still want the capability to dive deeper on a handful of specific topics that interests them.

Alright, let me show you some social civic designs built to fight information pollution.

Empowered Essentials

why: If we wish for citizens to rule responsibly, then they should be accurately informed when they vote.

who: For people who don't have a lot of time to explore politics, but still wish to participate responsibly in the process.

how: The Essentials make it frictionless for voters to engage in their democracy by providing basic information about polling locations, candidates, and the issues being voted on.

priorities: We value shared clarity for all voters.

what: When you type in your zip code, you get information that makes voting easier. A countdown that marks when your polling location opens, as well as directions to get there and its hours of operation. Where allowed, we provide copies of sample ballots to explore at your convenience.

You also get a list of every elected official that represents the people who live in that zip code sorted at a local, state, and federal level. You're able to click on the profile of any of your civic representatives to find their contact information, voting records, and a list of donors who have been funding their campaigns. This is done with the belief that every voter – regardless of party affiliation – should have a transparent understanding of who has been bankrolling their elected representative.

risks: The Essentials have failed when those that seek a shared solution don't trust it.

Empowered Compass

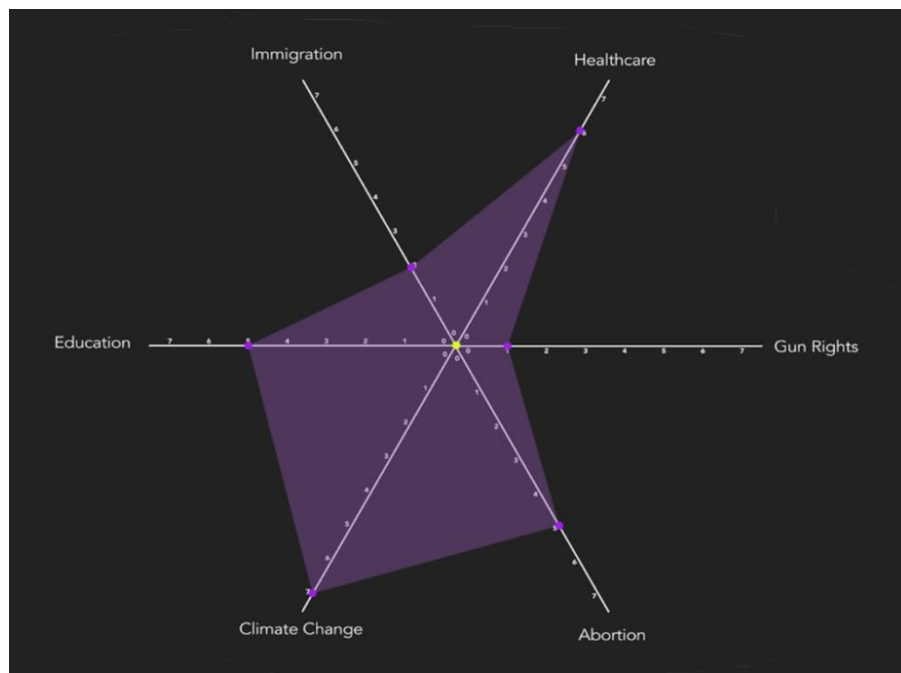
why: If we wish for a modern democracy to represent us more accurately, then we need tools that can help us reflect our unique civic perspectives.

who: This is for every voter that has a civic opinion that is important to them.

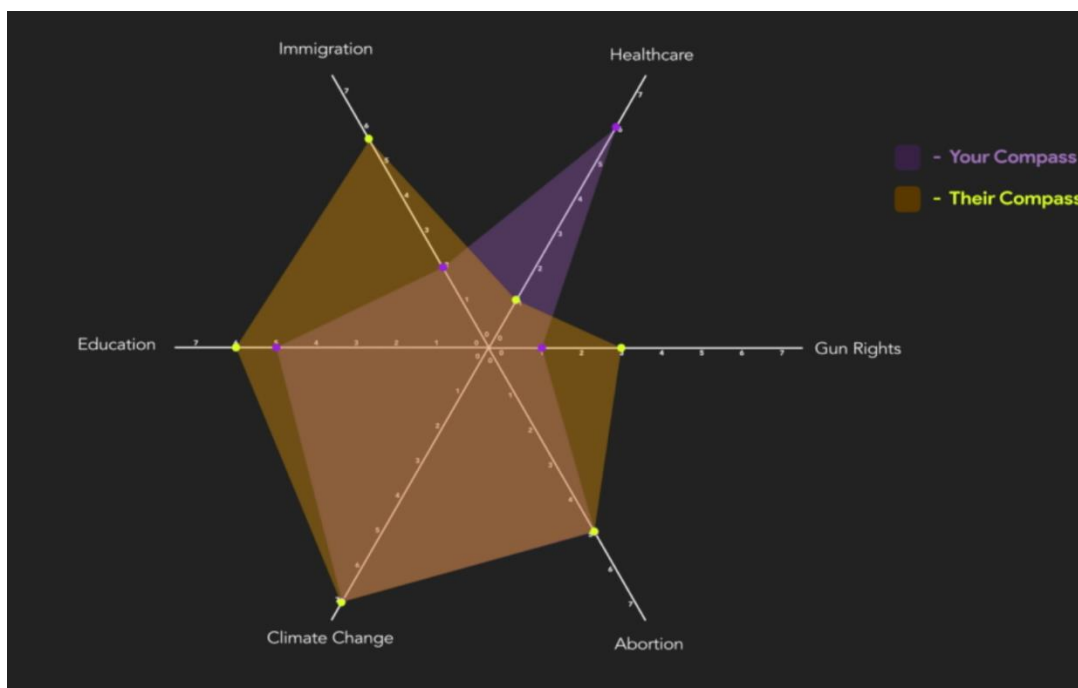
how: Your compass visually celebrates your civic priorities while allowing you to better understand how and where your policy positions match up with every Empowered Account.

priorities: We value the priorities of people over political parties.

what: You calibrate your compass by answering a handful of survey questions about your civic priorities. These are used to find a collection of the wedge issues that you find to be vote-worthy. When gathering this information, topics that may at first appear to be binary we seek to place along a spectrum because we find that placement leads to more nuanced understanding. We then take your primary, vote-worthy issues and display them upon a spider graph, as a visual mural of your civic priorities.



Once your compass has been uniquely calibrated to you, whenever you come across an Empowered Account on our platform, you will be able to quickly see how that person's values overlap with yours on the topics that matter the most to you.



You can also see how any Empowered Account personalizes the face of their own compass to quickly understand which issues currently matter the most to them.

risks: The compass can't calibrate correctly if none of the options describe the nuance of your stance. To keep the issues relevant over time, we task Empowered Accounts to submit additional perspectives to be presented as calibration options.

Also, taking a complicated issue and putting it on a spectrum works better for some topics than others. Since not everyone will see the same issues along the same spectrum, we enable each to personalize the order of the spectrum for their personal compass in the same way they are able to choose and position the spokes/issues that are represented.

Treasury Tracker

why: If we wish for citizens to pay for our government, then they deserve to know where that money is going.

who: This is for visual learners. And those in need of shared visuals to help illustrate a point for a conversation transpiring elsewhere.

how: We create a series of interactive graphs that allow citizens to visually explore publicly available budgets.

priorities: We value every voter having a comprehensive understanding of their civic impact.

what: When you select Treasury Tracker, you choose the lens you'd prefer to see it through – either at a federal, state, local level, or the summation of each. Beginning in broad strokes and then whittling down like a nesting doll, it allows you to explore our civic budgets with increasing granularity, providing context along the way.

risks: Visual learning aids benefit some more than others, so we know going in that this type of interactive exploration won't be for everybody.

For many, budgets are considered a pretty mind-numbing affair – so we have some fairly strong headwinds to make up for on that front, as well. We aim to make the complicated 'spreadsheet overload' portion of understanding budgets more engaging with motion graphics, iconography, and various forms of interactivity. We need our information presented in a way that you trust and feel proud to share with others.

Read & Rank

why: If we wish for our policies to come before our politics, then we need a systemic way to see those entities separately during an election.

who: This is for voters who have a few minutes to amplify their policy focus before heading to their polling booth.

how: Blindly sort from a list of eligible solutions.

priorities: Our evergreen focus is on understanding and empowering individual voters – not their political parties.

what: Leading up to an election, you are asked the same questions as those running for office. You read and rank their responses, but their identity is hidden until after you've prioritized the ones you align with. This way our focus remains first on your policy solutions rather than theirs.

risks: This feature may not have a large audience. There are comforts that come from wearing the armor of our political parties that this blind sorting cannot address. While cumbersome and inflexible, the armor that our parties provide appears to be critical protection when every civic conversation has become a battlefield. It takes a vulnerable courage to say "I don't know" and recognize that describes where you are in your process – instead of the killing blow it's often mistaken for.

Empowered Badges

why: If we wish for all of us to use the same facts, we need a tool to do that productively.

who: My understanding of the audience for this feature evolved drastically as I spent time with it. Originally, I saw it as a way to incentivize knowledge acquisition – a lot like collecting merit badges in scouts. Then I saw it as a bouncer providing VIP access to healthy conversations. And eventually I started nesting badges within others, and suspected I was laying the foundations for the Martian colony's first university.

how: Badges are created by Empowered Accounts that remain in high-standing with their Communal Council and maintain a high veracity rating. Every badge gets indefinitely scrutinized publicly along the Inform Pillar's values of evidence, engagement, and anti-partisanship.

priorities: We value the output of conversations that use the same facts as their foundation.

what: In its simplest form, an Empowered Badge represents a set of competency checks on a given subject; you pass the check, you unlock the badge and it becomes a social trophy to demonstrate understanding or proficiency.

For the Inform Pillar, I envision this similar to achievement questlines found in massively-multiplayer games; they are built as challenges to satisfy goal-oriented players. Elsewhere on Empowered.Vote, these badges may unlock access to new features or grant the ability to participate in conversations that you could previously just observe.

risks: There are quite a few editorial risks inherent in any form of news aggregation. We need a systemic way to ensure that the information that makes up each badge is accurate and anti-partisan – I'll introduce a couple of features to address this in just a moment. We also need to determine how difficult it should be to get a badge – too easy and the work feels like an annoyance, too hard and no one will be interested in the accreditation.

Veracity Rating

why: If we wish to use the same facts we must have a way to trust the same sources.

who: This rating should never prevent a new voice from joining the conversation, but there should be amplification ramifications when we find a history of continually spreading disinformation.

how: This is a personal rating built from a transparent set of values as applied to the posting history of every Connected Account. Everyone that wishes to post content on our platform will have a Veracity Rating that gets shared with the post to highlight how accurate that poster's 'facts' have historically been.

priorities: We value evidence-based discussions from sources we collectively see as reliable.

what: One of the benefits of authenticated accounts is that it allows us to track the origins of Information Pollution. Whenever any piece of content is posted to our platform, we look to study the long term impact of that contribution. Over time, we quarantine those who have a history of continually spreading information that is later verified as false.

risks: There are many risks in the weaponization of such a rating system, though they are far eclipsed by the risks of us continuing without one. Especially if the rating system we develop can be governed transparently by a shared set of values.

Emparks

why: If we wish for every voter to understand with nuance, then each must be empowered to ask for more answers.

who: While the conversations that stem from them can be viewed broadly, Empowered Marks - or Emparks - can only be placed by authenticated accounts, either Connected or Empowered.

how: Emparks are one of our primary feedback tools on a platform designed to amplify your impact, so in that sense, they tend to carry a lot of weight while wearing a few different hats.

Emparks come in different shades to match what they flag:

- Yellow indicates a clarifying question was asked
- Orange represents a request for shared evidence
- Blue indicates a guided conversation is being conducted on this topic

priorities: We value sharing the same facts; this frequently requires enhanced scrutiny of focus on specific topics for the benefit of all.

We also value every authenticated account having the capacity to publicly contest the facts being used.

what: Once logged in, you can context click anywhere on our platform to place an empark to ask a follow-up question, ask for shareable sources, or discuss the points raised more deeply. Each member can only have a handful of emparks posted at a time, though this number can fluctuate with use and as our capabilities increase.

Emparks are context sensitive based on where you place them. If you put one on a feature or blog post from Empowered.Vote, it provides us with a direct line to your feedback, so that we can better understand it. If you place one on an article, you can ask a follow-up question or endorse one that has already been asked. You can also track the various emparks posted by any Empowered Accounts that you follow or any friends who have given you permission to do so.

The other side of you placing these little digital thumbtacks all over our platform is showing what we do with them after they're placed. As we analyze a heatmap of the emparks that come in, we start to get a better picture of where we collectively have clarity and where we don't.

These communal points of feedback create a vector to track journalistic accountability. They allow us the opportunity for focused follow-ups with the author so they might provide clarification, address any broadly found fallacies, or highlight the need for a communally shared FAQ.

risks: There are broad yet significant risks associated with anyone tracking our interests – though the Connect Pillar's values of privacy should provide some evergreen protections for the public for as long as they are maintained.

Fallacy Finders

why: If we wish for our society to become inoculated from the manipulative effects of logical fallacies, then our society must become broadly proficient at spotting them.

who: This is for friends hanging out. In the same spirit as playing bar trivia – where there is a competition to beat others in your area, but everyone in earshot is on your team.

how: Fallacy Finders is a team-based competition to search for a shared set of logical fallacies in civic conversations. You play it on your phone or computer while hanging out with your friends.

We present a video on a civic topic and then we add buttons around the edge of the screen. Each member of your team is assigned a handful of logical fallacies that they guard against. As they see the fallacy occur in the video, they press the corresponding button for points. Between rounds, the fallacies get mixed among teammates. Cooperative table-talk is encouraged – so if you spot a Loaded Question or an Ad Hominem attack, you can still call it out for your team, even if that's not one of the fallacies you're currently assigned.

Having friends you trust help you spot logical fallacies is one of the easiest ways to learn to spot them, independently.

priorities: We value an electorate that is universally proficient at spotting the abuse of logical fallacies.

what: Due to the vulnerabilities that they target, it can be incredibly difficult to spot a logical fallacy occurring in real time without practice. And while this learning is greatly enhanced when it is beside those you trust, that won't be an option for everyone. So we also maintain a set of Empowered Badges that explain the ways logical fallacies are commonly wielded against the unaware.

Understanding how and when these weapons subtly distort productive conversations helps everyone that longs for a shared set of facts.

risks: It's possible that our goal is right but our game is not. And that we should explore other ways to parse through the noise of Information Pollution to teach people how to protect themselves from this rampantly prevalent form of manipulation.

Civic Trivia Championships

why: If we wish for Democracy to work towards the interests and goals of the people, then the people must remain engaged with civic problems, despite the constant, distracting roar of Information Pollution.

who: Civic Trivia Championships is designed to be played solo or in small teams by a group of friends hanging out. You don't need an account to play, though there are some internal rewards you can win if you are also logged in.

how: It plays like a cross between a game show and pub quiz – with the focus of each question centered upon a civic concern.

priorities: We value broad engagement in civics because the people cannot lead responsibly when we don't see the same problems.

what: Our trivia games are played along different points of focus, with matches found at a local, state, federal, and global level.

While playing, you might come across stories you weren't aware of or want more context on. So each answer comes with a list of sources that you can click to save and explore later.

risks: There remains broad risks of news aggregation that this feature depends on but doesn't solve. How we select the topics that become trivia questions may eventually become a vulnerability for manipulation without strong safeguards in place.

These make up the founding set of features for the Inform Pillar. Throughout, we use modern game design principles to compete for the attention of citizens against modern distractions. As our world has evolved to become more demanding of our limited focus, the attention that our Democracy requires has not abated. If anything, the challenges we face have grown more nuanced and complex than those that faced our forefathers. And so our methods of civic education must also evolve to fit the times.

That's why our goals are not based on specific outcomes but shared values; because the systems that stem from the latter last longer. So while every feature we make will be a constant work in progress, the Inform Pillar's search for shared evidence that is both engaging and anti-partisan will be evergreen.



Connect

The Connect Pillar was built upon three core beliefs:

- We must protect the conversations of citizens.
- Difficult discussions are guided by shared values.
- We only focus on solving shareable problems.

There are some thorns hidden amongst these three, so I'd like to explain each a bit further.

When it comes to protecting our conversations, our focus is always on doing what we suspect is best for the citizen. When we protect our conversations from anonymity, our concerns center upon the flood of disinformation that comes when we aren't using authenticated accounts.

When we protect civic conversations from transparency, our aim is to protect citizens from any government against their interests. When you look across the globe at the vast spectrum of what passes for a Democracy, you can find cautionary tales of what happens when the will of the people is silently overtaken by an Oligarchy or Autocracy. How they target dissenters. Among the first things to fall is a free press, being replaced by a mouthpiece of its despot that spews forth a flood of ambiguity and disinformation, ravaging shared foundations like a swarm of locusts.

The same foundational concerns of having a state-run media should also extend to any attempt to convert Empowered.Vote to a state-run civic platform. Our platform exists as an independent layer between a citizen and their government with the goal of protecting the citizens of every democracy before the governments of any. While our focus initially is to develop features for those who live in the United States, the values we hold dear are not held as American rights, but human rights.

When we all use the same facts, it is the smartest decision that tends to guide us; when we use the same values, it is the wisest among us. But when the pollution is thick around our knowledge and we don't know what framings to rely on, as a people, we tend to turn to whom we trust. Or who our family and friends trust; our modern tribe. But this tendency in times of stress to consolidate around increasingly smaller groups of loved ones can be exploited by those that seek to destabilize our unity.

When our conversations become too polluted to rely on shared information for our decision making, then we become vulnerable to manipulation. With the right stimulation, our latent fears get twisted into a powerful hatred while targeting scapegoats that can't fight back. This dominance over our enemies creates a temporary salve for fear, though it must be fed a steady diet of hatred to stay satiated.

But the capacity for these nefarious tactics to exploit our biases vanishes in the instant we choose to search for the same set of facts and wish to grow wise to their manipulative methods.

The Connect Pillar leverages many of the same techniques as professional counselors and mediators to build systems that help us bridge the delta in our differences. A common refrain from those who study interpersonal conflict is that while every relationship is unique, the vast majority of our relationship breakdowns occur in rather predictable ways. Which means they also tend to have rather understood solutions.

So when it comes to facilitating difficult discussions, productively, we focus each conversation on a handful of broadly shared values. These value-driven discussions give us a shared goal to start the conversation off or return to when we hit an impasse. And while different issues may prioritize different goals, there is one value that is held universally across our platform: We only focus on shareable problems.

For example, if you are focused on hating your neighbor – for whatever reason, even 'valid' ones – it's unlikely that your neighbor would be willing to share in that same hatred of themselves with you; it wouldn't be healthy for them, even if they could. So in that hatred, you'd be focusing on an un-shareable problem.

Systemically, when we focus on problems that our partner doesn't have, we become comfortable with solutions that are found at their expense. The issue is not how justified our hatred is or isn't – it's whether we are seeking a shared solution in our exchange and how our hatred and apathy prevent that from happening.

The features of the Connect Pillar aim to make our civic conversations safer and more productive so that we can collectively sort what we value in our solutions.

The next set of social civic designs were built to oppose Political Polarization.

Connected Accounts

why: You do not need an account to use any of the features of the Inform Pillar; it's open to everyone. This includes the ability to witness all of the features of the other pillars.

But for the foundation of the Connect Pillar, if we wish to protect our conversations from technology's modern manipulations, then we must constrain each person to having one voice in our discussions.

who: While everyone can observe the conversations that transpire in the Connect Pillar, to join those discussions or use its features, you must first Connect your account. This is Empowered.Vote's way of verifying that you are who you say you are, that you live where you say you live, and that you're seeking shareable solutions.

how: To ensure equity of opportunity, it will never cost money to Connect or Empower your account.

While the methods we use to authenticate your identity will need to constantly adapt as our technology evolves, the goal of ensuring each person can contribute only once should remain constant.

priorities: We protect our conversations from anonymity.

We will never sell your data to anyone.

what: Productive civic conversations require accountability.

It should feel like we're both sitting in the middle of a public town hall, aiming to use the same facts to find shared solutions. Strangers, perhaps – but strangers in a public place. Contrasted to the anonymity of a chatroom where vitriol can cower behind obfuscation and lies are peddled based on identified vulnerabilities. Civic Conversations will never be productive when they are held on a platform where anyone can join the conversation from any country and pretend to be anyone else.

risks: Forcing people to authenticate their accounts before engaging with others introduces a significant hurdle to widespread adoption right out the gate.

To address this during our path to market, our pilot features are being built for those in college communities. I suspect it will be the students of political science, philosophy, game design and computer science that will drive early adoption and make up the core of our first cohort.

Civil Civics

why: If we wish to find and be guided by our communal values, then we should have a digital town square that connects us, equitably, where we might collectively explore and systemically protect those values.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that wish to engage with others in their community.

how: Once your account is authenticated, you gain access to a set of civic hubs at a local and state level that anyone can observe, but only the people who live in that area are allowed to post in.

priorities: We value conversations happening at a local level when they are guided by locals.

We value equity of opportunity for all.

what: When you Connect your account, you gain access to a personalized set of semi-private communities based upon your geographic location. This allows you to talk with others in your district or state with a confidence that it's only the people in your community who are participating in that conversation.

In addition to protecting our discussions from foreign influence, this walled garden becomes a great resource for elected officials or those wishing to run for public office as it gives them a place to speak directly with their fellow constituents on individual civic topics. Having this back and forth with your representative can lead to solutions that are collectively built. And if your representative isn't there to listen, then we've created a civic hub to discover leaders that do. With every Empowered Account in the conversation clearly identified, it allows you to see at a glance how the solutions in their Compass align with yours.

Our opportunities for leadership in civic change are most pronounced in our local communities. With the way the ratios play out, we tend to have more influence in small groups than large. However, due to the reach of modern technology and the way cable news gets aggregated, most of our collective focus is on Federal or International topics, where our individual power is the most diluted and our impact is felt the least.

By modernizing local civic infrastructure, we help every neighborhood, every city council, every school board meeting be more efficient in accomplishing their goals. By building our platform upon a transparent set of values, we can make this infrastructure equitable for all.

This means that if you move to a new town, Civil Civics provides a consistent experience as you transition to your new community, providing a familiar interface as you connect to your local civic impact group.

risks: Initially, I suspect our largest hurdles will be around driving even adoption. There are familiar struggles for start-up social media platforms – where you need conversations already happening to drive the traffic to organically make more conversations. But there are also concerns unique to our polarized landscape that we should be wary of if we wish to grow into a haven for more than just the red team or just the blue team.

Equal Slice

why: There's a weakness in majority rule that democracies have long struggled to contain; embodied in the contradiction of the slave owners that signed our first draft. It's referred to as the Tyranny of the Majority to describe an inclination of those in the majority to use their democratic advantage at the expense of those in the minority to keep them in the minority.

When this is being done with intent is where value-driven designs really shine; by committing beforehand to certain shared values around equity and privacy, we can put safeguards in place to protect all of us from this type of oppression.

But as our world evolves to fight for more of our attention, it's not just malice that can cause this type of tyranny, but ignorance. As our concerns grow and become more complex, we reach a threshold where the only problems we have time for are the ones that affect us, personally.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that want to engage with their broader world productively.

how: Where Civil Civics uses technology to isolate and amplify local conversations, Equal Slice takes larger groups – think Federal or Global – and along transparent and adaptable metrics, we divide the broader whole into smaller slices. Each slice representing a cohort of people, varying in size from that of a small church to that of a small town depending on the nature of the issues being discussed.

The people who make up that cohort stay consistent for around eighteen months. During this time, they explore geopolitical topics together, have the opportunity to present communal solutions, and can connect to a diverse community that is proportionally representative of our whole, while giving every person a community small enough to hear the topics from other perspectives.

After eighteen months, half of each cohort are traded with another with the transparent goal of keeping each slice equitably diverse and represented proportionally as the broader whole.

priorities: We combat availability heuristics by leveraging technology to increase the range of who is available.

what: The first Equal Slice we are developing is a Federal Slice – but the design is scalable and as we expand, we can apply the same techniques for other countries, eventually making a Global Slice and our descendants will be able to use the same principles and frameworks to one day bring unity to an interplanetary species.

As our civilization scales, many of our foundational problems with communicating stem from a lack of awareness. And for those problems, the various slices should provide a ‘local’ iterative community to explore federal or global topics.

risks: The process in which we determine how to cut each slice needs to be malleable to change while transparent in design.

To find a shared solution that lasts for everyone, we proactively find those most marginalized and make sure they have an equitable voice in our discussions.

Symposium

why: We seek to modernize our debate format into something more productive.

If we wish to solve shared problems, we need to productively unpack what we communally value in our solutions.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that want to find and sort shared values on civic issues.

And for Empowered Accounts that want a voice in leading their community.

how: Symposiums are a series of supported conversations that are focused on wedge issues. Each individual conversation is roughly forty minutes long with the tournament portion of the Symposium lasting approximately six weeks before shifting to its next topic.

Empowered Accounts discuss what they value in a civic solution while an audience of Connected Accounts determines which of the solutions proposed resonate with them the most – thus determining which Empowered Accounts will advance to the next round.

As the tournament progresses and fewer participants remain, there is a natural pull towards sharing the same values as your audience; because that's the win criteria for both Speakers. In instances where both Speakers' values on that issue are uniformly aligned and sorted, the focus for that conversation shifts to tactics. Each Speaker then presents a set of Objectives that they believe will best accomplish their shared values.

At the end of the Symposium, these Objectives are gathered, sorted, and ratified on the Awareness Exchange. We then use these Objectives to guide the features built in the Empower Pillar.

priorities: We value conversations that use the same facts as their foundation.

We facilitate conversations guided by shared values.

We value solutions built from shared objectives.

what: Symposiums begin in the Inform Pillar with an Empowered Badge that describes a set of facts that will be used for that discussion.

Much like a trial beginning with discovery where each side presents the evidence that will be used for that case, a Symposium begins by presenting, scrutinizing, certifying and eventually ratifying a shared set of facts for that discussion; the output of that ratification is its corresponding badge.

In order to increase our chances of landing on a shared solution, we separate our conversations about veracity from our conversations about values. By removing the pollution that surrounds polarizing wedge issues it becomes easier for us to share our problems and see them inverted from another perspective. There is no progress in discussing what we value in a solution if we don't yet see the same problem.

About a month after its badge has been ratified, the tournament portion of the Symposium begins. It's a modern debate tournament, where the speakers only defend the sides they believe in. This takes a specific topic and for about six weeks, we take a communal deep dive as we focus on finding shared values and shared solutions for that problem.

Speakers are randomly paired up and take part in a series of guided, public conversations on the chosen topic. These discussions are facilitated with targeted prompts, time-boxed responses, and are built with hooks to make viewing an interactive experience. We also leverage the frameworks from other features in these discussions, like fact-checking with an Empark or watching a Symposium with the Fallacy Finders overlay on to help track the logical fallacies being found in real time.

Since Empowered.Vote is only searching for shared solutions, our conversations naturally tend to gravitate towards broadly shared values. This tends to reshape the structure of the discussion a bit. When we don't share the same values, we often need to fight to be understood. But when each of the values are intended to be shared by everyone, then our collective focus is less a matter of omitting our opposition and more a matter of prioritizing one of those shared values over another.

Each of these structured conversations are conducted transparently by the systems of the Symposium but are guided by Connected Accounts – those that have unlocked the same badge and so are using the same set of facts. During the live discussion, we provide opportunities for these viewers to impact the direction of the conversation, allowing them to collectively choose the next topic or ask for clarifying follow-ups. At the end of the discussion, the Connected Accounts who watched will determine the outcome of that Symposium, voting for the speaker's values that they prioritize higher. Deciding which – if either – of the speakers will advance to the next round.

risks: Determining the topics of focus for our Symposiums is exploitable without strong safeguards in place. The typical loop for these types of ratifications is to have Empowered Accounts propose the options with Connected Accounts voting to determine the outcome.

Communal Council

why: In crafting our Democracy, our forefathers replaced a magistrate's ruling with one that would be determined by a jury of their peers; settling on twelve jurors, chosen at random from the affected

community. Fewer and they were concerned the people wouldn't be consistently represented but more would be untenable due to the time obligations that this new justice system would require of the general public.

Communal Councils revisit the constraints our forefathers faced at either end of this dilemma.

We seek a modern approach to criminal justice that has systemic and transparent protections against inequality built into the process.

If we wish for citizens to rule, then we need to explore modern ways to codify their judicial power.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that care about the ways we treat others while on Empowered.Vote.

how: The Communal Council sees its authority upon Empowered.Vote and nowhere else. So any decisions, arbitrations, cases, and punishments that come from a Communal Council are intended to extend only upon our platform.

But with those boundaries firmly in place, we seek to modernize our justice process outside of the institutionalized constraints of our justice system.

Here, we seek to constantly iterate on the ways that we communally find justice by preparing and presenting cases beforehand, stopping to scrutinize for equity in our approach via shared values, and then delivering these completed arguments to a Communal Council to get their verdict. By building a justice process that leverages the reach of technology to scale indefinitely, we are able to treat the number of jurors as a variable – where cases with more interest can scale beyond the hard limit of twelve. With each voice randomly added increasing the fidelity that the verdict they determine will more accurately represent their community.

And for the jurors, we streamline the arguments presented to be mindful of their time constraints and attention span. By preparing each case beforehand, it allows us to ensure each juror can see facts with a uniform clarity.

This approach allows for systemic checks in our process, where each case can be monitored for shared standards of equality and clarity before being shared broadly.

And then once it is presented, it provides a vector for Connected Accounts to make their voice heard.

priorities: It is not the values of justice we revisit, just the methods.

what: The focus of a Communal Council will change based on the nature of the concern and the community that the offense affects.

When orange Emparks are placed on conversations to request shared evidence, we need a systematic way to determine the veracity of facts that get challenged. A Communal Council for that Empark will be guided by the values of the Inform Pillar to determine in an anti-partisan fashion if the facts being used are based on evidence.

For the Connect Pillar, discussing the nuance of our values frequently leads to interpersonal conflict. Communal Councils can be used in these situations, but are typically approached as a last line of defense, preferring to first exhaust our systemic solutions.

But there are times when posts are so egregious in their offense that they call for the removal of its author from future conversations. Or times when we identify an antagonistic intent – the difference between accidentally spreading misinformation and intentionally spreading disinformation. And in these instances where our collective values have been disrupted, instead of Empowered. Vote turning against its own, we prefer to quarantine the offender and facilitate a Communal Council to let their peers determine next steps.

risks: The greatest risk of any iteration on our systems of justice is that the revised system will no longer point towards justice. This collective concern weighs so heavily that it stifles innovation in the guise of defending ancient precedents instead of shared values.

Communal Councils are meant to be modern laboratories to explore judicial principles. These councils are not built as a replacement for a government's justice, though they are intended to encourage modern innovations in our criminal justice process.

Issues in Focus

why: If we wish to treat unrelated problems as if they were unrelated, then we need our conversations organized by topic instead of party.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that value expertise – seeking or developing – on subjects of civic importance.

how: Earlier I introduced the Empowered Compass, which visualizes your stances on wedge issues that you find to be vote-worthy. Due to their divisive nature, we've taken each topic that can be selected as a spoke in that compass and given it a dedicated hub where you can search for solutions with others. We call this putting that issue in focus.

Frequently, issues that initially seem unrelated are found to be interconnected in ways we don't anticipate. The goal of putting individual issues in focus isn't to deny these connections, it's to make their motivations more transparent. We refer to these relationships between disparate issues as 'Causal Links' and they are identified, explored, and endorsed by authenticated accounts.

priorities: We value collectively unpacking complicated problems free from the distractions of unrelated issues.

We value solution-oriented conversations that aim to solve shared problems.

what: When we put our Issues in Focus, we create a hub that is designed to explore that topic, productively. We then seek to understand your stance better. In your words if possible, but in ours if time is the constraint.

We categorize consistent responses and then explore the relationships between our differences. Each of these separate hubs also helps us develop a shareable framework for that problem that can later be converted into an Empowered Badge, which can then be ratified by that community.

risks: When the community is only welcoming to one perspective – be it for or against – then no shared progress can be made.

Also, if someone is working against the values in our pillars then, for that individual, no shared progress is being pursued.

Common Ground

why: If we wish to find shared solutions, then we must find shared problems.

who: This is for Connected Accounts that are looking for a productive conversation on a topic with a stranger that they disagree with.

Or Empowered Accounts looking for a public place to search for shared solutions.

how: Common Ground was heavily inspired by a mediation technique called adversarial collaboration. In both techniques, there are two divergent thought-leaders and an arbiter that operates transparently to facilitate the mediation.

The two opposing thought leaders collectively come up with an experiment that they believe will conclude differently to prove their point. Each makes a called shot on the expected outcome and explains why their prediction will be correct and what an alternate outcome would represent.

The arbiter helps identify logical fallacies and cognitive biases in both approaches and asks clarifying questions to ensure both see the upcoming experiment with shared clarity. With those parameters in place, they conduct the experiment together and all three parties describe their findings.

This process leads to more shared solutions, systemically, because it isolates shared values first. Then once our values are agreed upon, we find shared facts through experimentation and shared observation.

Once alignment is found with both our facts and values, then the solution they point to becomes a tactical matter that can be guided by transparent metrics.

priorities: We value the solutions that stem from shared problems.

what: There are different variations of Common Grounds found throughout Empowered.Vote:

For Local and State issues, Common Grounds are held on a weekly basis in Civil Civics.

For Federal and Global issues, Common Grounds are held weekly with others in your Federal and Global Slices.

For every vote-worthy issue presented in our Empowered Compass, we hold sign-ups for monthly Common Grounds where we put that Issue in Focus.

Blue Emparks are placed anywhere on our site and represent conversations where someone disagrees with a central thesis that has been presented. If the discussions behind these Blue Emparks are granted

enough weight by the community, we create Common Grounds to support the exploration of that conversation.

The Common Grounds that are shared between two Empowered Accounts are intended to be slower, more comprehensive affairs. We introduce engagement hooks for Connected Accounts to shape the nature of that discussion or experiment, including the ability to endorse an outcome. We refer to these as 'Shared Grounds' to highlight the shift away from isolated explorations.

Each Common Ground is considered a public conversation that can be viewed by everyone.

At their conclusion, we ask all three parties if the exchange was productive. In situations where all three say yes, we look for the conversations where someone changed their mind. Only when these criteria are met, do we seek to broadly amplify the exchange.

risks: Those that threaten others will be governed by the policies of their Communal Council and removed from conversations to keep them productive.

Tolerance Reach

why: Insulated echo chambers keep us from focusing on the same problems but our society won't collectively abandon these modern fortifications of thought without addressing the root cause that has us burrowing deeper within our isolated realities in the first place.

If we seek to facilitate productive disagreements, then we need a way to predict where those conversations are found.

who: For Connected Accounts, your Tolerance Reach is set by your Tolerance Rating, a semi-private metric based on how you engage with others productively while on our platform. The way this rating is determined is uniform, transparent, and reviewable at every step.

If a Connected Account decides to Empower their account, the details associated with their Tolerance Reach and Ratings become public knowledge.

how: We seek to create dynamically adjustable echo chambers for each person based upon their personal triggers. This provides the benefits of safety that we seek in an echo chamber by limiting the

reach of hateful and counterproductive contributions while still pooling the vast majority of our civic perspectives in one place instead of separate islands of isolation.

For Connected Accounts, your Tolerance Rating sets your sphere of influence on our platform, with a higher rating correlating to broader reach. If this rating goes down, we let you know privately and in detail where, when, and why – with any contested infractions resolved through a Communal Council.

This framework provides us with the means to reduce the reach of vitriol in our discussions, dynamically, on a person-to-person and topic-by-topic basis.

priorities: We value conversations held with productive intent, where our collective focus is on solving a shareable problem.

what: We guard your Tolerance Rating in the same ways that we guard your identity; we don't intentionally share it or sell it to others. Unlike your Veracity Rating (which is shared broadly with every post), we approach your Tolerance Rating as a private conversation between us.

This gives us a venue to quietly and directly raise awareness with you if we notice a vulnerability to a certain type of logical fallacy or arguments that target manipulative biases. When we discover topics that trigger a less than productive response, we should track them to best serve both you and the broader conversation. We determine your reach in a transparent fashion – with accountability hooks in place so the process can be overseen by the community to ensure that we are never working against the interests of our members.

risks: A high tolerance rating doesn't indicate "correct" views or the strength of a person's arguments or solutions. It says nothing of the merits of a person's policy positions and one foundational risk of this system is an inability for an evergreen audience to broadly understand that nuance.

Instead, a high Tolerance Rating indicates a knack for disagreeing with others while not actively being disagreeable; an inclination to see a tantrum and respond with patience instead of annoyance. This type of leadership may not always point the right way, but it is critical in shepherding the rest of us to a shared solution.

For many of the same reasons that we should find the most trusted when working with our facts, we should also search for the most patient if our aim is to find shared values; ascertain the bridge builders that want to see both sides of an argument and seek to bring harmony to disparate opinions. These are the leaders that we want to empower and Tolerance Ratings are among the metrics we use to find them.

Empowered Gems

why: For their first few decades, video games exclusively used closed economies; where players might earn Credits or Gold Coins to purchase items found in-game, but they were earning and spending a currency that only existed in that game. Closed economies are a great boon to system designers since they can be leveraged to create compelling incentive structures that can also periodically be reset and refined to best suit our shared needs.

If we wish to have a civic platform that is free of financial influence, then we must remove the impact that money can have on our platform.

who: You must have an authenticated account to earn or receive Empowered Gems.

how: Each Empowered Gem is the tool of a systems designer to incentivize healthy play patterns and should never be sold or traded for goods or services outside of our platform.

In game development, when you give a strategic advantage to those who spend more money, the game stops being an accurate representation of skill; Gamers call this ‘pay-to-win’. In that same vein, we will never sell more gems to anyone – ***Empowered Gems will never be a revenue stream for our platform.*** That is seen as the game design equivalent of ‘selling power’ on a platform designed to promote equity.

Instead, Empowered Gems are earned through participation – with the majority being provided as a stipend to members on an expected cadence. You can bank the gems that you don’t use up until your reserve is maxed, at that point your gems are treated as ‘use it or lose it’ and the excess will go away with the delivery of the next stipend.

And since every Empowered Gem only lives on our platform, we are able to transparently track the origins and travels of each gem that gets spent.

priorities: We value everyone having access to an equitable voice in our discussions, free from the distorted amplifications of monetary influence.

From Empowered Gems to advertisements, we will never sell influence on Empowered.Vote.

what: Empowered Gems amplify the volume and focus of your civic impact. Due to the iterative nature of our platform, we want each feature to be able to operate independently with its own closed economy. This means that Empowered Gems earned in one area may not always be spent elsewhere.

In the pursuit of equity, we may at times wish to iterate on the distribution of our civic power and having isolated closed economies helps us minimize disruptions when we make these revisions.

risks: Great pains have been taken to develop a civic platform that is insulated from the influences of wealth. Empowered Gems aim to provide everyone with an equitable voice in determining our civic solutions. We must resist the constant temptation to sell any form of this civic power. It is not that there isn't a market in selling civic influence, it's that selling influence distorts the goals of our civic markets.

Awareness Exchange

why: If we wish to be guided by the wisest civic minds that are among us, then we need a way to find them.

who: This is a game for authenticated accounts that enjoy making predictions.

how: The Awareness Exchange is a stock market simulator where civic issues are treated as stocks and facts are approached as bonds. Each Connected Account is given a quarterly stipend of Empowered Gems that can be 'invested' into solutions presented on this exchange. As solutions grow in popularity over time, the 'payout' for an early endorsement increases.

priorities: We need to collectively remember the efficacy and origins of our solutions.

We aim to find those who make the right predictions with the highest frequency and celebrate them. As we find those who consistently turn a healthy 'profit' on the Awareness Exchange, we also find those with the greatest track record of picking the right civic bets.

what: The Awareness Exchange represents a voter's ability to identify and amplify a specific civic solution upon an equitable platform. Many of the features that I previously introduced have some presence on the exchange:

- When a fact is contested in the Inform Pillar, gems can be spent on the Awareness Exchange to predict the veracity of the fact. A portion of these gems may act as a 'bounty' for further investigation that resolves the dispute.

- Civil Civics provides a local version of Empowered Gems that are only distributed to the citizens of that community to better understand their local priorities.
- Objectives ratified at the end of a Symposium can be further endorsed by the broader community through this exchange.
- Causal Links that have been proposed between disparate issues can be explored and endorsed with an investment of Empowered Gems.
- When a Shared Ground is sought between two Empowered Accounts, anyone may invest in predicting the outcome of their experiment.

With these various investments of Empowered Gems, members can demonstrate their ability to predict civic outcomes. As they amass their fortunes of our imaginary currency, we will collectively find those most adept at navigating our civic issues.

And as we watch our communal investments upon the Awareness Exchange fluctuate in support, we will see the solutions, objectives, and causal links that the community collectively endorses. Understanding the focus and will of citizens with clarity and granularity will be critical as we prepare for the challenges of the Second Mars Problem.

risks: In the distance, there is a problematic point of growth for this feature where it could potentially lure voters away from their best interests in pursuit of increased gains within the Awareness Exchange; where a heavy investment in our currency might pollute a person's motivations to embrace the truth when found.

I don't have a strong solution for this, yet, though it's possible this problem is avoided by periodically resetting the Awareness Exchange through a predictable cadence of seasons, where investments made in a previous season become 'locked in place' while continuing to pay dividends of Empowered Gems at that season's rate.

These make up the founding set of features for the Connect Pillar. Here, we use technology paired with our evolving understanding of behavioral science and cognitive therapy to facilitate at scale productive conversations between strangers. All of this in pursuit of amplifying each voice that longs for shared solutions.

My primary struggle in designing social systems in a vacuum is that every iteration can only be an educated guess until it's nourished by the feedback of the community it was built for. I've taken these frameworks as far as I can by myself. As I linger longer with each, I build solutions for the shadows of problems I anticipate with an educated awareness that I will never catch them all. And I won't need to; a necessary part of a vision that outlives you is empowering the next generation to carry it along after you.

The conversations of the Connect Pillar – and the values that it unpacks – must always be what guides our platform. In a moment, I'll introduce the tools of the Empower Pillar, built to support civic leaders that are looking for shared solutions. Since power traditionally pools towards leadership, there may grow an unspoken expectation that this final pillar is our most critical. But when there is conflict between them, it should always be the voices of the Connect Pillar that guide the leaders in the Empower Pillar.

In the same way my mom wouldn't let me both cut the last slice and choose which piece I wanted, we need to put systemic checks on leadership so that they always serve the common good instead of their own interests. In a Democracy, the ones who rule are intended to be bound in service to those who do not.



Empower

The Empower Pillar was built upon three core beliefs:

- Equality demands Equity of Opportunity.
- Leadership gets the second slice.
- We preserve the legacy of the next generation.

The features of this third pillar are future-facing to guide our way and are designed to help civic leaders facilitate impactful change.

Pursuing equality can cause problems when there isn't a shared agreement on what that specifically targets; at Empowered.Vote, our focus is on the equity of input rather than output. To use a board game to describe that delta, equity of input would mean that everyone starts the game with the same resources for a fair match; equity of output implies after the game is over, all the points get evenly redistributed before deciding on the 'winner'. When we seek the former, we create healthy competition where the outcome is determined based on the skill of the players or from the wisdom of their choices. For clarity, we refer to this focus on parity at the onset as Equity of Opportunity and it is intended to chase a platform that provides an even playing field to each member regardless of their race, income, gender, or nationality.

When seeking the latter – where equity is determined at the output – players lose incentive to try their hardest, comfortable in the knowledge that no matter how they play they will have already 'won'. There are few biases more potent in their frustration – or more manipulative – than watching others get systemic benefits that you believe are unfair or unearned. By attempting to redefine equality to mean something that is 'unfair or unearned' it creates a false narrative where it's no longer a desirable value.

Equity of Opportunity also extends to the relative power of each voter. To ensure that our evergreen focus always caters equally to all, Empowered.Vote does not provide any civic advantages to those who

can afford to pay more money. This includes a ban on all advertisements with currencies other than Empowered Gems.

When the wealthy have the loudest impact in our civic conversations, they tend to promote policies that protect their own interests at the expense of the common good. Over time, this accumulation of power leads to generational wealth and a modern day nobility. We have children that are born billionaires while others are born into starvation; and in both cases, it's not the choices that either child makes that has determined their fate. Our entire society misses out when only a handful have been given the equity of opportunity to succeed.

These last social civic designs were built to end Civic Impotence.

Empowered Accounts

why: If we wish for our civic leaders to operate in our interests before theirs, we must indefinitely hold them to a higher degree of accountability and transparency.

who: Only Connected Accounts may choose to convert to an Empowered Account.

how: Before you may Empower your account, there is a badge you must unlock to ensure there's a shared understanding of what being an Empowered Account entails. We also ask that you fully populate and maintain your Empowered Compass, as this representation of your civic priorities becomes public facing when you make the transition. Beyond that, though, there aren't any significant barriers; to ensure equity of opportunity, there's no entry fee or subscription service or payment plans. The main 'cost' associated with Empowering your account is the loss of privacy around your civic perspectives.

Unless explicitly stated, it's assumed an Empowered Account retains the abilities of a Connected Account.

priorities: We only value leadership when they are held accountable by the ones they lead.

what: If you choose to Empower your account, you are offering your services as a Civic Steward.

risks: There are some evergreen dangers in transparency; representing a loss of privacy that won't be a fit for everyone at every stage of their life.

To protect the individual, Empowered Accounts can 'demote' back down to a Connected Account at their convenience.

Ranked Choice

why: There is a False Dilemma at the heart of our politics – a belief that you must take all of the solutions from either the red team or the blue to find a path forward. This logical fallacy is made possible by an archaic design at the heart of our voting process that leads to the 'Spoiler Effect' in our elections.

Currently, if you are thinking of voting for a third candidate, our voting system punishes your civic impact and makes it more likely that neither of your top options will get elected. Additional candidates that are similar to your favorite 'split the vote' of their influence. Over time, this forces voters to think strategically about the political machinations of their vote instead of the candidate that reflects their civic beliefs the most accurately. I believe this focus on politics as we vote has an unhealthy influence on the leaders that we elect acting like politicians instead of civic servants.

If we long for a Democracy that represents the will of the people, then we need to accurately understand their will as they vote.

who: Anyone with an authenticated account may vote on our platform with a frequency that suits their needs.

how: When you vote with Ranked Choice, you can vote for as many people, policies, or solutions that you want. You rank them by determining which choice is your top pick and second pick and so forth.

When it comes time to tabulate, your vote remains with your first pick until it's clear they have no way of winning and every remaining candidate has more votes. And then instead of your civic impact ending with that candidate, your support shifts over to your second pick and the whole tabulation begins again, meaning that every voter will have their vote counted for as long as even one of their choices is still in the running. This cycle repeats until one candidate receives sixty-seven percent of the vote or there are only two candidates remaining and one receives the majority of the votes.

priorities: We represent the will of our community as accurately as we can, free from the distorted motivations of politics.

what: When the systems of our civic infrastructure encourage us to vote against a candidate to make sure they don't win rather than for the candidate we want to win, then we've weaponized our society's capacity for hatred and we become vulnerable to manipulation through our biases. A divisive candidate doesn't need to develop solutions or even solve problems; they just need to stoke hatred for the other candidate and be the only other option.

But this manipulative tactic is ineffective in voting systems that allow for the nomination of multiple candidates. If anything, Ranked Choice incentivizes candidates to collaborate and find common ground instead of inspiring hatred and division. Because if a candidate can't be your first pick, there's still a tactical advantage in them becoming your second choice. When we change the design of the system so that our leaders are rewarded for finding and solving shared problems rather than stoking hatred and division then we remain focused on the solutions they present instead of the biases they aim to exploit.

risks: When a voter has perfect knowledge of how every other voter has ranked their votes, there remain some theoretical edge cases that leave Ranked Choice culpable in producing a spoiler effect. That doesn't stop this sorting from being infinitely better than our current system, but it does mean that as our technology continues to evolve we must remain vigilant to always represent the will of our community. Just as our forefathers provided the best framework that their time allowed, so must we, and one day so must those that come after us.

Empowered Candidates

why: When it takes wealth to run for a democratic office, then it is only the wealthy – or those beholden to them – that are permitted to compete in the process.

If we wish for our elected leaders to first support the common good, then they need a way to get their solutions in front of their constituents without fundraising being the primary hurdle to their success.

who: This is for Empowered Accounts that wish to run for elected office based on the strength of their solutions.

how: We provide every candidate with the same Equity of Opportunity to run for elected office; free from the financial and ideological constraints imposed by the ones that fund our political parties. Many of the features we've introduced from the other pillars were also designed to provide parity for Empowered Candidates:

- Empowered Essentials, Treasury Tracker, and Read & Rank provide a standardized 'just the facts' approach to explain the stances and solutions of each candidate.
- Citizens can explore the nuances of their own Empowered Compass and then are given a comprehensive list of elected leaders who align their compass in a similar way.
- Civil Civics provide a venue for local leaders to discuss their solutions with others, as long as those solutions are intended to be shared by all.
- From Symposiums to Common Grounds, Empowered.Vote seeks to provide structured conversations that get to the root of our civic differences while in front of an audience of Connected Accounts.
- The Awareness Exchange allows citizens to track the various civic endorsements of each Empowered Candidate. This includes transparency around when and where each investment was made.

There are additional features from the Empower Pillar that I'll introduce in a moment, each developed to help leaders articulate their solutions with clarity and transparency. We may briefly trust a stranger based on what they say, but we should know our leaders by their actions.

When paired with the same facts established in the Inform Pillar and the shared values unpacked in the Connect Pillar, the Empower Pillar creates a critical third point of data to fully understand the solutions proposed by our leaders. By providing clarity around every bill they write and every amendment that candidate has proposed, citizens can track if a person is being honest about the values they profess. The same way we need shared clarity around our facts, we need transparency and shared understanding around where our loopholes are being created. Because the same leader that makes one loophole with malicious intent will make thousands; refining their methods of obfuscation with practice.

priorities: We use technology to democratize access to lead our Democracy.

what: When an Empowered Account decides to run for public office, we celebrate that as the antithesis of Civic Impotence. And as a matter of purpose, we do whatever we can to equitably empower that voice. As long as a candidate is earnestly searching for shareable solutions, then they are welcome on our platform.

Every Empowered Candidate is given a campaign site, creating a hub where voters can hear from them directly and explore the nuances of their proposed solutions. Voters can watch past appearances in Symposiums or Common Grounds, explore a comprehensive list of all registered donors through Empowered Essentials, and then they can compare their values against the bills, amendments, and solutions that the candidate developed.

risks: Modern technology may allow us – for a fleeting generation – to remove wealth as a necessity to get elected. But if our civic decisions remain driven by two political ideologies instead of earnest conversations, then wealth’s power will eventually return. It’s simply too cheap and the rewards too great when you only need to purchase two sets of politicians to cover 100% of the market.

Empowered Endorsements

why: If we wish to choose our leaders based upon their solutions, then we must know them by their actions.

who: This is for Empowered Accounts that want to propose a civic solution on the Awareness Exchange.

It’s also for Connected Accounts that are looking to make a positive impact in their community.

how: Empowered.Vote was not created to pursue profit. In our next chapter, we explore the existential risks of any modern civic platform and in that context I'll explain our business model in more depth. For now, an efficient summary is that we are crowd-funded by micro-donations.

In the event we cover our costs with some money to spare, that remainder doesn't go to any shareholders. Instead, Empowered.Vote puts that surplus into a transparently monitored fund that empowers our members to make a focused impact in their communities.

Empowered.Vote then creates a specific allotment of Empowered Gems distributed to every Connected Account that can be spent on the Awareness Exchange to support the solutions that resonate with them the most. As those investments reach certain thresholds, Empowered.Vote amplifies the impact of that civic focus with an investment from our surplus fund.

Every solution presented or endorsed on the Awareness Exchange must also be guided by the values of our pillars. This includes anti-partisanship and a blanket refusal to donate money to any political party or campaign and a refusal to support any hate-based groups as they're not searching for shareable problems.

The shape of this investment is set and monitored by Empowered Accounts. In this way we can see, sort, and select our leaders by the impact of the solutions they develop and endorse.

priorities: Our focus is on building an infrastructure to solve the Two Mars Problems before funding any solution on the Awareness Exchange.

Iterative communities – where our actions have an impact on the ones that know us – breed communal trust.

Citizens must feel their civic impact or they won't notice as they are losing it.

what: Initially, we keep the projects that are eligible for these donations constrained to solutions with a very small budget; preferring to support ten leaders with ten dollars before one with a hundred. But as Empowered Accounts demonstrate aptitude, accountability, and leadership with their solutions, they're encouraged to target even larger problems and organize with other like-minded leaders, increasing their collective accountability.

Our focus is on building small solutions that can make an outsized positive impact in their communities. We do this to encourage the discovery of leaders through their repeated civic successes.

risks: Historically, value-driven organizations become more vulnerable to corruption when they begin accumulating and distributing funds. This pooling of money represents an evergreen risk to Empowered.Vote's priorities and it is with this focus that we built this feature. So that we have a

consistent, systemic way to transparently handle excess funds while building solutions and developing leaders that make a difference in our communities.

Roles

why: I admire the design of games that have planned asymmetry where players can opt into different roles to celebrate their preferred playstyle. You might play as a protective knight, a powerful mage, or a restorative healer – each providing a distinct lens through which a player can approach the same content. Supporting different character archetypes provides game designers a framework to cater directly to the varying needs of players' personalities and their desired experiences.

If we wish for citizens to have a focused impact in guiding our platform, then we should develop frameworks where they can amplify their impact along the vectors they are drawn towards.

who: Members can transition between different Roles like wearing different hats. To ensure our leadership always gets the second slice, we prohibit wearing two different hats while using the same feature.

As we identify systems that require increased accountability, then any associated Roles need to be filled by Empowered Accounts.

how: In many of these designs, I've sought to create 'citizen-shaped holes' so that the impact or focus of a specific feature can ultimately be guided by citizens instead of those who govern Empowered.Vote. We seek to future-proof the focus of our platform from later generations with systemic checks to ensure Empowered.Vote always serves the goals of citizens, first.

An essential tool in designing systems that will always support citizens' interests is to build the citizen directly into the design of that system.

priorities: Roles may gain specific privileges on Empowered.Vote and should expect to face increased scrutiny around the use of those privileges.

what: These examples are not intended to be an exhaustive list, but should hopefully describe the general shape and purpose of having 'citizen-shaped holes' in our designs:

- **Mavens** – Filled by Empowered Accounts, Mavens specialize along an Issue in Focus. As a community, they help us with the design and curation of Empowered Badges and develop the questions for Civic Trivia Championships.
- **Journos** – Filled by Authenticated Accounts, the Journo archetype is ideal for data journalists and content creators. The community around this archetype establishes shared standards for evidence-based journalism and the applications of our Veracity Ratings.

Whenever information is submitted to the Inform Pillar, it is created or endorsed by Journos – and then validated by Mavens and Arbiters, using a double-blind process. This doesn't prevent the spread of misinformation, entirely, but this system provides shared accountability amongst strangers when misinformation is found. By blindly randomizing the validation process we minimize the likelihood that their conclusion is fraudulent.

- **Arbiters** – This Role is for Authenticated Accounts who are adept at spotting Logical Fallacies and Cognitive Biases; ideal for someone that enjoys playing Fallacy Finders. Arbiters mediate Common Grounds and other difficult conversations while using their expertise to validate Journos' submissions for the Inform Pillar and help develop Empowered Bills.
- **Moderators** – This Role is primarily for Connected Accounts and is ideal for community organizers. Supporting the needs of this archetype helps us to create the tools that Mods need to serve their community, effectively.
- **Jurors** – This is for Authenticated Accounts who want to help us get better. This familiar 'citizen shaped hole' helps us systemically sort our conflict through Communal Councils and Symposiums.
- **Educators** – This is for Authenticated Accounts that enjoy explaining concepts to others. They help create and validate our Empowered Badges and teach us how to better teach others.
- **Guides** – This Role is for Empowered Accounts and most closely resembles traditional civic leadership. Guides speak in Symposiums and Shared Grounds or organize around local solutions in Civil Civics and make their case by articulating the causal links they endorse while building value-based solutions.
- **Scribes** – This Role is for Empowered Accounts that seek to articulate collective values into tactical solutions through legislation.

Both Guides and Scribes work in concert to develop civic solutions, representing a systemic division of focus in their approach. I'll explore this relationship in more depth when introducing Empowered Bills.

risks: The social structures that stem from these Roles may one day lead us towards new tribes or political parties. The concern here centers around any group voting as an unthinking block instead of for the same reason. Distinguishing that delta is critical in us combatting the biases that target our society; 'mindless' support of anything based upon a collective identity can make that identity vulnerable to targeted manipulation.

Empowered Filing

why: When tax preparation accounts for a billion dollar a year business, we create powerful interests that benefit from us maintaining a more complicated tax code. Increased obfuscation around our tax laws means they can only be governed with clarity by tax accountants, paralegals, and those with the funds to attain their support.

If we wish for citizen's to know their civic impact, then they should have clarity around where their tax dollars are going and the origins of that policy decision.

who: This is for any citizen of the United States, regardless of whether or not they have an account on our platform.

how: Leveraging the same visual language and teaching techniques developed to support the Treasury Tracker and Empowered Badges, we seek to provide clarity around our tax code to all citizens for free.

priorities: Empowered Filing is focused on explaining the sources of our tax code before providing personalized tax advice.

what: One of the primary benefits of Empowered.Vote is the interconnectedness of its disparate features. For instance, while exploring your tax forms through Empowered Filing, you may at times want to better understand how those levied taxes support your community. So throughout an empowered tax form, its details and origins are explained using the methods and features previously introduced in the Inform Pillar:

- Explore your tax forms alongside the Treasury Tracker, which visualizes the budgets relevant to the taxes levied.

- Place Emparks on specific sections of our tax code or track the questions and clarifications posted by others.
- Empowered Essentials provides transparency around the authors and supporters of each line written in our tax code, including that legislature’s campaign contributions and the reception and efficacy of other solutions they have previously proposed.

We embed the clarity of the Inform Pillar throughout our tax forms to provide a shared understanding of the services funded by our taxes.

risks: The knowledge this feature provides should assist the majority of Americans in filing their taxes with confidence. But our success is not found when every American pays the right amount of taxes. Rather, our aim is for citizens everywhere to be able to collectively identify why each tax was levied at a granularity of detail that satisfies them. It’s only when we are accurately armed with an understanding of our impact that we gain the capacity to shape it towards our interests.

Radical Transparency

why: As we design for an audience generations out, we must look for the cracks that take generations to develop and then build systems that can solve for those problems. It’s with this lens, I sought designs that could indefinitely protect our platform from its own leadership.

who: Radical Transparency targets the leadership of Empowered.Vote with the same scrutiny of focus that we apply to our elected officials.

how: In the same way that the Inform Pillar provides a shared foundation and the Connect Pillar unpacks our shared values, the Empower Pillar gives us a way to see our leaders develop civic solutions in front of us.

Having transparency around our leaders' actions and funding becomes critical when we suspect they might be professing one set of values while adhering to another.

By developing solutions in front of citizens, Empowered Accounts create a critical third point of data to help voters see if a leader's values align with their actions.

priorities: We seek shared clarity around our facts and solutions so that our conversations can be guided by our collective values.

what: Transparency is never easy but it is *easier* when you start early.

From its beginning, Empowered.Vote seeks to document the discussions behind our development so that context can help shape necessary revisions. This commitment to transparency also extends to the compensation of each leader within Empowered.Vote, including all developers drawing a salary in the top 25% of the organization and a report of what they were working on.

risks: No matter the nobility with which we embark, if history is our teacher, we must prepare for a generation of sociopaths to one day take the helm of our platform and put systemic safeguards in place for their inevitable arrival. Transparency around the decisions and motivations of our leadership is critical in validating their authenticity.

But while transparency is necessary for clarity, it is not the same thing as clarity. Flooding citizens with information you know they're not following does not lead to their consent – especially in conversations that have actively been designed to be difficult and convoluted to understand, like a terms of service 'agreement' or the nuances of parliamentary procedure.

Martian University

why: For society to maintain equity of opportunity, every person must have access to an equitable education. When only the wealthiest among us have access to higher learning, then their advantages will continue to pool with their wealth.

who: This education hub is built for the children and adults of a theoretical Martian colony, though its applications extend far beyond that barren red rock.

how: By focusing on the ways the first generation of colonists might educate the next, we create a framework to see a useful set of shared problems that we can begin solving with technology today. With the engagement techniques we refine in developing Empowered Badges, we build lessons that create classes that support curriculums, developing an online education that is accessible to everyone for free.

In preparation for the needs of that colony, the Martian University acts as a modern hub for educators and parents to have focused, facilitated discussions about what an ideal curriculum looks like and why.

priorities: We seek a shared understanding of our problems before we discuss our values or solutions.

what: The first generation of colonists will need a way to educate the next. Technology thoughtfully applied to this problem can offer an equitable education to every Omega, based on humanity's collective learnings. The Martian University represents a comprehensive education that can be replicated indefinitely for every person on any continent or planet regardless of their wealth, gender, or race. Supporting students of any age - from kindergarten to postdoctoral – with interactive lessons that can be translated into any language. Because after the Age of Information, no one should live without access to an education.

risks: Our curriculums will always be in a constant state of revision as our collective understanding evolves. We need a way to empower Parents and Educators to explore iterations of lessons together, and then make changes to our approach based upon what they learned.

Modern technology can also give us a collective understanding of where our best educators are found so we can celebrate and replicate their best practices. We seek to judge our teachers by their results – not by how well their students were prepared for a specific test – but by how well those students were prepared for their life. That type of analysis typically comes long after a teacher has retired and requires a long and reliable memory that bridges generations; quietly following the trajectory of each student so we can judge their education accurately.

When we shift the success criteria of an education from a student's test score to a student's success after they leave school, then we create a healthier lens to judge our Educators.

Empowered Bills

why: As the systems of our government become more complex, the process of creating our legislation grows increasingly difficult to follow. When a bill's intent is obfuscated behind thick layers of legalese and its debate is confined to an archaic parliamentary procedure, then only the most educated are able to follow the nuances of governing. This creates an unhealthy feedback loop where those with the capacity to manage complex legislation are in a position to make our legislation unnecessarily complex, effectively reducing their oversight.

If we long for a healthier way to make laws, then we need a platform where every citizen can collectively and transparently iterate on our solutions.

who: This modern workflow entwines a transparent system of checks and balances throughout the development of our bills. It's designed to support Guides, Scribes, and Arbiters in determining civic solutions and Connected Accounts that want to show their support.

how: This is a ten-step framework that uses our collective values to guide the creation of our legislation:

1. A problem is identified and placed on the Awareness Exchange.
2. Connected Accounts spend Empowered Gems on the Exchange to highlight shared concerns.
3. Guides take prominent problems and articulate a set of values they believe will lead to its resolution, presenting those values beside the problem on the Exchange.
4. Connected Accounts are then able to ratify the values that best encapsulate their desired solution.
5. Scribes draft legislation to capture the intent of the ratified values.
6. Guides make a 'called shot' as to the expected impact that the bill would make; creating a vector to judge our solutions by their expected outcomes.
7. Arbiters verify that the legislation's intentions are clear, concise, and aligned with the previously ratified values – and then return it to the Awareness Exchange as an Empowered Bill.
8. Guides work with Mavens and Educators to build an Empowered Badge to support the explanation of the bill.
9. Connected Accounts ratify Empowered Bills found on the Exchange with an investment of Empowered Gems.
10. Empowered Candidates run on a platform of enshrining these collectively built bills into our democracy.

At steps 2, 4, and 9, every Connected Account has a voice in determining the problems, values, and solutions that we collectively decide to Empower. Each member can also place Emparks if they seek clarity on a wording or would like to raise a concern. By threading citizens throughout the legislative process and separating key responsibilities amongst different Roles – we can bring transparency to each step of our development, track the sources of corruption, and ensure every loophole has a detailed origin story.

priorities: We seek transparency around the creation of our solutions.

what: This framework for creating laws is scalable and can support local leaders as easily as those running for Congress. When we clearly isolate each step, it creates transparency and accountability throughout our legislative process. When we structure it so that our collective support comes after our collective understanding, then there is broader investment in the solution.

risks: At its onset, my concerns center upon this ten-step process being too complicated to inspire broad adoption.

Dem 2.0

why: Our democracy was established a century before electricity and doesn't allow our modern marvels to manage our laws or leaders with nuance. The process of writing legislation has largely been outsourced to private think-tanks that are bankrolled by the same special interests that fund the campaigns of our politicians. Our sources of information are rewarded financially for promoting polarizing perspectives while our leaders are rewarded politically for dividing our country.

If we wish to prepare for the next generation's legacy, we must look at the problems they will face and set the stage for their success. It's with this aim that we use shared values to collectively ideate and prototype a modern democracy as empowered by technology. Instead of revising our current government, this feature focuses on solving the Second Mars Problem: What would an ideal democracy look like for the citizens of the first interplanetary colony?

who: As those first colonists depart, they will embark with a united hope for the survival and prosperity of their entire community. The collective self-interest of the Omegas creates a useful lens to view our civic struggles. By placing our focus on our children's legacy instead of our children, we create opacity around our audience that is critical to our design process being equitably applied. When our leaders

can't benefit from their proposals, it encourages the search for value-driven solutions while helping us avoid many of the pitfalls that lead to racial inequality and generational wealth.

how: My country's forefathers had just three weekends over the course of a summer to negotiate the foundational frameworks of our government. If they failed, those fragile colonies would have collapsed and the leverage that pressure created forced a compromise that gave root to a civil war.

In place of three weekends, we seek to spend a generation to collectively design and methodically develop a modern Democracy - not for us - but for the colonists born beyond Earth that will soon need it. We take a value-driven approach to ensure we always see the same frameworks when searching for shared solutions. Leveraging the same tools that help us mediate productive conversations or explore the merits of a piece of legislation, we determine what an ideal democracy would look like and discuss why.

priorities: Every feature at Empowered.Vote is intended to pave the way for this exploration to happen. To design a better Democracy, we need to base our discussions on shared facts so we might explore shared values and find shared solutions.

We only value a democracy when its leaders remain beholden to its citizens.

what: The conversations here are intended to productively decide what our next Democracy should look like. Our focus is in finding the ideal state of society's stewardship - explored without the constraints and compromises created by our corruption. Once we have a shared vision for what that solution looks like, we prototype portions and get feedback from our communities to steer our path forward.

When there is a disagreement in our approach but each direction has merits of support, then we systemically iterate on our solutions through Shared Grounds. This gives us a repeatable framework to predict our outcome, apply different solutions to separate Equal Slices, and then observe the results together.

risks: If we don't proactively solve the Second Mars Problem, we will force its reckoning upon a future generation. By the time the leaders of that colony are chosen, our opportunities to obfuscate the identities of our audience will be obsolete. We have a generation, right now, to design for that colony a better way forward. A modern democracy that uses technology to empower its citizens. Connecting, protecting, and representing the entire colony equitably by building it upon a foundation of well-defined and commonly shared, inalienable values.

With a love for those we'll never meet, we develop a more perfect union.

These make up the founding set of features for the Empower Pillar. Here, we create tools that transparently and equitably empower our leaders, free from the financial constraints of the donor class and the intolerance inherent in our political parties. We build these frameworks so that the leaders of tomorrow might use our examples to prepare their world for the generation just after them, the one they'll never know.

Throughout our platform, any civic solution may be pursued as long as it is constrained by the beliefs found in our pillars. In review, the beliefs that guide the Inform Pillar seek a shared foundation for our civic conversations:

- Facts should be supported by evidence.
- Information should be engaging.
- Our approach should be anti-partisan.

With these beliefs, we have the tools to authenticate our knowledge through public accountability. When our knowledge is no longer polluted by manipulative tactics and logical fallacies, then we can focus upon the same problems and solve them for the same reasons.

Likewise, the beliefs of the Connect Pillar lead us towards a shareable set of values that strive to make us less polarized in our approach:

- We must protect the conversations of citizens.
- Difficult discussions are guided by shared values.
- We only focus on solving shareable problems.

When we collectively decide to honor these beliefs as we engage with each other, we create a framework that will always seek to solve shared problems.

And finally, the beliefs of the Empower Pillar seek to enhance our civic impact while aligning us around our desired end state. Here we create a platform where citizens can choose their own leaders based on the strength of their solutions rather than the size of their bank account:

- Equality demands Equity of Opportunity.
- Leadership gets the second slice.

- We preserve the legacy of the next generation.

These beliefs will always aim to modernize our democracy upon a sustainable path that serves the people. As we iterate on these features, we move slowly and idealistically, guided by the voices of Connected Accounts, so our people may move forward united in our understanding, focus and efforts.

6 risks

My greatest concern in bringing forward these features is that a subset will be replicated in execution but perverted to support values that make their leadership more powerful at the expense of those they lead. After spending time with each design, I recognize with a haunting clarity their unbridled capacity to insulate decision makers from accountability as they steer features and discussions towards their interests. If one day there comes a generation that wields a version of these solutions without the accompanying values of our pillars then each would spoil and have the combined capacity to bring catastrophe to any promise of Democracy. We need solutions for this problem that will stand the test of time; not just for today or the next generation, but we must design our systems so that even many generations from now - long after they've forgotten us - our platform still stands and strives to serve citizens.

That's the focus of this penultimate chapter; I'll explore the three risks that sit atop each of our pillars and the systemic solutions developed to solve them:

- How do we find shared knowledge?
- How do we authenticate our values?
- How do we find the leaders that long for shared solutions?

While these questions have hounded our species since our first communities, we are the first generation with the capacity to permanently solve them.

How do we find shared knowledge?

Where I grew up we had a saying, ‘the easiest way to catch a snake-in-the-grass is to cut the grass’. By leveraging Connected Accounts, we can collectively remember

The next time you’re speaking with someone and recognize you both have a different understanding of the facts, watch how you both respond to that realization.

When there is pollution around our information, we won’t trust the Inform Pillar to provide the foundation for productive conversations. In those moments, we must turn to the other pillars to stay upright.

With every piece of information posted tied to of Connected Accounts to pr the accountability that comes from the other pull authenticated accounts

Accountability from Connect

Transparency from Empower

Information is how facts become knowledge.

How do we authenticate our values?

Aligned Pillars

How do we find the leaders that long for shared solutions?

Citizen Shaped holes

Non-profit

Crowd-funded – no ads – micro-donations at your lunch. Funded transparently by the people.

Accountability, Alignment, Goals

Transparency, Citizen Shaped Holes, non-profit



The First Mars Problem:

How do we end war before it ends us?

There will come a generation that collectively decides to bury the grievances of their forefathers and refuse war long enough to build evergreen protections against its return. Beyond the First Mars problem, it shall be the voices that chose forgiveness that will be there to guide the way.

The Second Mars Problem:

What's the best democracy we can design for those born to Mars?

Our ancestors survived for thousands of generations driven by productive curiosity. And for all that time, outside of a couple discoveries in the middle ages, the exploration of the heavens had really only held a fool's pursuit.

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That's all I got for now. Sorry it's not finished; I write frustratingly slow. Going forward, I'll try to add slightly longer drafts with patch notes to my [Patreon](#) page. They'll be available for anyone to download for free.

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